

NURTURING TRUTH



Lisa Heise
Western Technical College

Nurturing Truth

Writing Creative Nonfiction with Patience and Purpose

Lisa Heise

Western
Technical College

2025

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

This text was compiled on 05/17/2026

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

1: Introduction

2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain

3: Bring Form to the Storm

4: Content

5: Writing Standards

6: Artistry

7: Openings and Closings

8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage

9: Voices and Truths

- 9.1: Bad Ass
- 9.2: The Crabby Contractor
- 9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?
- 9.4: In Sight of Myself

Works Cited

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Image Attributions

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

1: Introduction

Why we tell stories:

Stories build cultures. True stories build entire civilizations, belief structures, and communities. Since humans could communicate, stories have been shared. Some of the earliest cave drawings discovered from 30,000 years ago tell tales of the challenges and victories of living at that time. Indigenous people across the globe pass stories through generations. Moral structures are built from stories. Centuries-old texts full of narratives are used to convey truths, to warn, to inspire, and to instruct in faith communities of all kinds. Storytelling is entertainment, it's instruction, and it's foundational to our humanity. It's kind of a big deal.

On a smaller scale, stories help us connect with others every day. They help us empathize and find commonalities. At the end of each day when I connect with my son, who is a high school student, I ask him for stories. When I want to encourage or warn or correct him, I offer stories of my own mistakes and triumphs. When I meet someone for the first time or teach a class full of new students, I ask for stories and share my own in order to know them better.

My college-age daughter is living in Brazil. She interacts with people from all around South America, the U.S., and Africa. When meeting someone from a place she hasn't been, she has learned to ask for stories. "What is your hometown known for?" she asks. The true stories they share are sometimes more fantastic than fiction.

She recently met a new friend from Honduras, who shared that her hometown is known for *lluvia de peces*, translated as "rain of fish." At least once a year, this region experiences a unique meteorological phenomenon in which fish literally fall from the sky. They explain the phenomenon through—guess what? A story about a local clergyman who prayed for his community to receive food during a time of famine, which resulted in the first fish storm. Is the story true? It sure feels true at least once a year when the skies get dark and everyone runs inside to avoid getting pelted by plummeting seafood.

Vikki Moran of *HerLife* Magazine sums it up beautifully:

Listening to a good storyteller can transport your spirit. With a skilled storyteller, you can experience changes in seasons, smell aromas and ultimately seed your open mind. "Spinning a good yarn" can shape culture, impart values and pay respect to the subject matter. We listen and interpret the meaning in stories we hear. It is very human, and it is essential to history. Storytelling is vital to language development and can assist in creating racial equality and religious respect.

Defining the genre:

Creative Nonfiction is seen by some as a new genre, sometimes referred to as "The Fourth Genre" (the other three being fiction, drama, and poetry). Frankly, that's weird and a little insulting. Creative nonfiction is probably the original genre, the first way knowledge was passed between generations. Is the word "Creative" the part that makes it new? Regardless, humans have designed beautiful or scary or funny or otherwise enhanced ways to convey truths since humans began to be human. Ancient Greeks and Romans saw themselves as conveyors of truth through narrative. Michel de Montaigne, who wrote hordes of personal compositions in the mid-sixteenth century, is known as the "father of the essay." Literary scholar William M. Hamlin speculates that Montaigne's essays influenced playwright William Shakespeare as he penned *The Tempest*. Shakespeare was sixteen years old when Montaigne's first book of essays was published, and the influence (concepts as well as diction) of Montaigne's essay entitled "Cannibals" on Gonzalo's musings in Act 2 of *The Tempest* are obvious (Hamlin, Go). Learning to convey truths about human nature was crucial to Shakespeare's mission as a dramatist, as he noted through Hamlet's observations:

"The purpose of playing, whose end, both at the first and now, was and is, to hold, as 'twere, the mirror up to nature." —
Hamlet, Act 3, Scene 2

Nonfiction, then, has been intertwined with fiction and drama in myriad ways, including powerful inspiration, in some of the most seminal works of western culture set on paper. At some point between the Elizabethan era and the late twentieth century, the perception arose that nonfiction needed to be reportage and exposition only: encyclopedias, newspapers, just the facts.

In the 1960s, a few landmark publications opened the gates to writing nonfiction in a literary way, and those gates remain ajar today. In 1966, writer Truman Capote published *In Cold Blood*, an unprecedented literary retelling of a grisly multi-murder in rural Kansas. Two years later, Joan Didion published her collection of essays entitled, *Slouching Towards Bethlehem*. American author

Tom Wolfe called Didion's nonfiction writing style "New Journalism," a phrase picked up from his colleagues. Other writers, including Gay Talese and Norman Mailer, were also expanding their nonfiction voices using literary conventions.

Next, in 1969, Maya Angelou published the first of a series of "autobiographical novels" entitled, *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings*. Angelou was a poet, and she wasn't looking to tell her story until a fateful dinner party the year after Dr. Martin Luther King's assassination. Having shared some stories of her childhood at the social gathering, Angelou was soon contacted by Robert Loomis of Random House publishers and offered a book deal. Her reply? "Absolutely not." Her priorities were poetry and drama, not autobiography. Dinitia Smith recounts the story in her 2007 *New York Times* article, "A Career in Letters, 50 Years and Counting."

Mr. Loomis tried another ploy, phoning Ms. Angelou and saying, "It's just as well, because to write an autobiography as literature is just about impossible," she recounted.

That did it. "I said, 'I will try,'" Ms. Angelou remembered, in her majestically deep voice. Out of their phone conversation came "I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings," and about 20 other books written by Ms. Angelou for Random House.

Perhaps coincidentally (and probably not), the same year Angelou's first memoir installment was published, the term "Creative Nonfiction" was first used by literary scholar David Madden in his book, *Survey of Contemporary Literature*, noting that the sound of truth had again transcended basic reportage or exposition. It was time for a new name (Moore).

Nonfiction is a weird word, beginning with a negative, implying that it is lacking something. If fiction is *not* true, nonfiction is NOT *not* true...right? Writer Philip Gerard argues that defining a genre by what it is not, as with nonfiction, is "...like defining classical music as *nonjazz*. Or sculpture as *nonpainting*."

Is it only English that undoes or negates this genre in such a unique way? In Portuguese, it keeps its "non" status: *ficção* vs. *não ficção criativa*. In Polish, fiction is *fikcja* while nonfiction is *literatura faktu*. Make it creative, and it's *twórcza literatura faktu*. I think I like the Polish name best. Literature of fact.

In English, as best we can tell, the term "Creative Nonfiction" originated as a term in the late twentieth century when writers wanted to differentiate this literary genre in which expository writing, journalism, sometimes research, are all hanging out together, but they invite the sexy celebrities of fiction to the party: vivid sensory imagery, figurative language, maybe some alliteration or assonance or their various cousins...the genre remains true, but it becomes more stunningly true. Is it the same as Montaigne's mental meanderings? I'll leave that up to you, if you can stay awake while trying to read through an entire essay of his.

In summary, we have given ourselves permission (again) to write truth in beautiful ways, and we have named it, perhaps by accident or by default, Creative Nonfiction.

Now, let's get to work.

This page titled [1: Introduction](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain

Gathering ideas for nonfiction essay topics is commonly called brainstorming, though that, too, is a weird term. Storms are usually unpleasant, while gathering ideas is the absolute most fun adventure. I prefer to call the process of coming up with true story topics a mind-rummage or a memory hunt or an untrivial pursuit or an epic-quest-to-uncover-that-story-only-you-can-tell-in-a-wonderful-way. For this chapter on figuring out topics, though, I will bend to convention and agree to call this curious journey... brainstorming.

The way you brainstorm most effectively depends on several factors. Everyone perceives and remembers differently—literally everyone, according to a 2018 brain study conducted by the University of Zurich. Genetic makeup, lived experience, and even our chosen professions impact the synapses and regions of our brains we use most, rendering our individual brains as unique as our fingerprints. How your mind works to recall and build narrative is too complex to define or predict, so it's important to try a few different strategies in order to understand what is most effective for you.

Wall Storm

Many writers prefer to let ideas simmer before the words form on the page, which is why placing them in plain sight for frequent perusal is a great idea. Whichever method you choose to generate writing topics, consider posting them somewhere in your home or workspace that allows you to look at them often and add notes. A large piece of paper stuck to an office or bedroom wall will suffice. Otherwise, if you're a sticky-note fan, use them to generate ideas.

One-Word Prompts

Simplicity may be the best method to get your creative wheels turning. One great place to look for simple prompts is the MOTH story hour. MOTH is a podcast and radio program as well as a nationwide storytelling opportunity. Their rules for telling a story are that it must be true, and it must be about you. You could even visit a live Story Slam event and tell your story. Each event has a one or two-word theme, and from that theme you may find inspiration. Some Story Slam themes in Madison during 2024 were Hot Mess, Elbow Grease, Strange Encounters, Silver Linings, and Yes, Chef! Consider the number of directions you may take with any of these themes, from seeing an ex-spouse at the grocery store to burning a hot dog beyond recognition at the campfire.

Writer and professor Lee Zacharias suggests working from a limited list of one-word prompts. She describes her early writing ambitions surrounding the huge and tragic aspects of her life. Eventually, says Zacharias, she learned that “some of the most exciting nonfiction comes out of material that didn't seem important, out of the over-looked detail” (Ellis 45). She came up with a list of generic words and challenged her students to choose one word that “evokes a vivid and specific image” for the writer. “Dance,” for instance, may remind one writer of dancing in the kitchen while making dinner during the dark winter months of Wisconsin. It's me...I'm that writer. Another writer may think about their senior prom date, who ended up choosing a career as a stripper in Vegas. That writer is also me. The fun of it is that one word can lead you down a bunch of different narrative paths that you would not otherwise have considered. A few of Zacharias' (roughly 120) one- word prompts are...

Window

Fish

Box

Key

Spider

Pocket

Author Kathleen Spivak offers a similar strategy in the same text, the Creative Nonfiction-inspired version of *Now Write!* Edited by Sherry Ellis. Spivak, however, suggests finding a hard copy of a dictionary, closing your eyes, and pointing to a page. Use the word you find as a starting point, and start writing. Even if you don't end up with that starting word as the central focus of your essay, it still gets your wheels turning (21).

As a lover of all words, I'm especially excited by this method. The struggle, however, is that physical copies of dictionaries are hard to find in this tech era. I tried the same strategy using a literature anthology instead, which I found on my trusty, dusty office



- Character-based
 - First: Make a list of at least five PEOPLE that you know really, really well. A parent, a childhood best friend, a coach, etc.
 - Next: Make a list of at least five people that you would like to know more about: Elvis Presley, Eliza Hamilton, Your maternal great-grandmother, and so on.
- Location Centered
 - First: Make a list of five PLACES you can easily describe, places you have spent significant time. Your car, the public library, a local diner, etc.
 - Next: You guessed it—list at least five places you would like to know. Mt. Rainier, The Louvre, the local Humane Society’s cat room, etc.
- Time Spent
 - First: List as many HOBBIES or activities you can on which you consider yourself some type of expert: crochet, fly fishing, Minecraft, etc.
 - Next: List pastimes you would like to learn more about. Playing mandolin, milking a cow, collecting Pokémon cards, etc.

Now you have a list of about thirty potential essay topics. Add to the list, cross items off as the mood strikes, and refer back to it for every new project. Some topics will require information gathering. Some will come straight from your heart and your excavated memories.

Resources: PW.org

One beloved resource for Creative Nonfiction prompts is [pw.org](https://www.pw.org), the website for *Poets and Writers Magazine*. Each week, a free and beautifully composed prompt is added to the site. Here’s a screenshot example from June of 2024:



In addition to seeing the current week’s prompt, you can scroll through the archives and see several past options to get you started. These prompts are charming in their specificity, and they work well for writers who prefer a lot of structure to help them get started. These prompts also tend to teach you something new each week about some other aspect of writing or some fun fact in general. Here’s a [link to all the creative nonfiction prompts from Poets and Writers](#).

The best brainstorming strategy is couched in writing advice from Stephen King in his book entitled, *On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft*:

“You have to read widely, constantly refining (and redefining) your own work as you do so. If you don’t have time to read, you don’t have the time (or the tools) to write...not only will you keep up with what others are doing, but you’ll keep yourself inspired and open yourself up to new ways to tell your own stories.”

This page titled [2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

3: Bring Form to the Storm

Now that a stunning collection of ideas is swimming through your psyche (and your notebook, and hopefully, your bedroom wall), it's time to decide how to proceed in terms of form. Creative Nonfiction is the GENRE, but this genre is capable of being molded into several different forms.

A beginning writer may just want to start writing and see how the essay structure evolves as you write it. Avoid getting stuck trying to decide on a form if this is a sticking point for you. As Stephen King advises in his 1986 introduction to *The Writer's Handbook*, "When you sit down to write, write. Don't do anything else except go to the bathroom, and only do that if it absolutely cannot be put off."

If you have a little more experience, consider challenging yourself to try a particular form listed below. Above all, be ready to pivot. Let the ideas and words do what they want to do as you filter them onto the page. You may begin with a personal essay in mind and end up with a hilarious top ten list about what not to do on an international flight or a trip to the grocery store with a toddler. The way the work unfolds organically is part of the adventure. As you embark on that first draft, be open to any shape it may take. Alternately, start a few different forms using the same topic, and see which one your hands seem to be unable to stop writing. Here are some potential forms you might consider.

Memoir—The memoir is oriented in the past, whether early childhood or yesterday. It's different from autobiography in that it focuses on a finite era of the writer's life or a persistent theme. Lee Gutkind of Creative Nonfiction magazine observes, "The modern memoir is an offshoot of traditional autobiography, but though the two forms share the same umbrella, they claim different ground. The memoir tends to reflect a life organized by theme—drug addiction, for example, or illness—while autobiography is typically a linear catchall, a succession of facts plodding from birth onward."

Thematically, the memoir can carry any focus. The connotation of the word has evolved in American culture so the reader may expect some juicy content, some "tea" in the text. Gutkind agrees: "...narratives about the self, however they are structured, tend to have a scratch to itch, a bone to pick, so the author selects those damning details that stick in the reader's craw and make the story hard to shake." The origin and actual definition of the word, however, are from the French meaning simply, "memory." A memoir doesn't have to be confessional or damning. Writer Dani Shapiro, who has published FIVE books of memoir, all variously themed, says that "Most memoirists' impetus comes from a profound need to understand and be understood. The crafting, the culling of a story is an act of control. You're saying, 'Understand this about me, about my family, my history, my story'" (174).

For many, writing memoir is a way to sort and make sense of life experiences. Sue Monk Kidd, on reflecting why she feels drawn to writing memoir, says, "It's the unexamined experience that seems to wreak the most havoc on my day-to-day world. Writing memoir not only has the ability to reveal me to myself, it also has the power to change me. I suspect writing memoir is partially about the need to bring about wholeness in myself"(115). A writer should not hesitate to produce memoir simply because they have never committed a crime or saved a baby from a burning building or survived being hit by a train. Memoir writing gives us a chance to examine our memories.

Take a look at some notable memoirs as you develop your voice:

- *Fierce Attachments* by Vivian Gornick
- *I Could Tell You Stories: Sojourns in the Land of Memory* by Patricia Hampl
- *Lab Girl* by Hope Jahren
- *My Family and Other Animals* by Gerald Durrell
- *Pilgrim at Tinker Creek* by Annie Dillard
- *The Color of Water* by James McBride
- *The Folded Clock* by Heidi Julavits
- *The Road from Coorain* by Jill Ker Conway
- *The Snow Leopard* by Peter Matthiessen
- *The Year of Magical Thinking* by Joan Didion
- *This Boy's Life* by Tobias Wolff
- *Walking on Water: Reflections on Faith and Art* by Madeleine L'Engle

Here's Gutkind's complete exploration of the history of memoir: <https://creativenonfiction.org/writing/the-history-of-memoir/>

Personal Essay is tough to define on its own. Some use “personal essay” and “memoir” interchangeably because of the overlap content-wise. Who cares what the difference is, really? Both tell true stories. Memoir tends to imply more intimacy, deeper personal insight, and sometimes a “come what may” approach to sharing the writer’s own truth. [Susanne Farrell Smith](#) observes that memoir features the voice of the past self as well as the present, while the personal essay is more in the present. The personal essay, according to Smith, seeks to relate more to the audience instead of just focusing inward. “The writer,” says Smith, “paints herself against the backdrop of humanity.”

The bottom line is that it doesn’t matter what you call your writing. Like the toddler debate about whether it’s raining or sprinkling, maybe memoir and personal essay have enough in common that the Venn diagram is a blob with minimal differential cleavage and isn’t worth getting your heart poked in the debate. Here you go:

[You poked my heart! \[YouTube video\]](#)

Biography: Telling someone else’s story is biography. It’s a tough form to navigate if you see things differently than your subject. You must make a choice as a writer to honor the truth of your subject or to honor your own truth while telling the subject’s story. Read some notable biographies as you consider whether this is the form you want to try:

- Rebecca Skloot's *The Immortal Life of Henrietta Lacks* (2010)
- Ron Chernow's *Mark Twain* (2025), *Washington: A Life* (2010) --Pulitzer Prize winner; *Alexander Hamilton* (2005, Inspired Lin-Manuel Miranda to write *Hamilton the Musical*)
- Stacy Schiff's *Véra (Mrs. Vladimir Nabokov)* (1999) – Pulitzer Prize winner; *Cleopatra: A Life* (2010); *The Witches: Salem, 1692* (2015)
- Catherine Clinton's *Harriet Tubman: The Road to Freedom* (2004), *Mrs. Lincoln: A Life* (2009)

Travel Narrative: Go somewhere. Tell about it in a beautiful way. Be real. Share the ugly as well as the fun. In her introduction to *The Best American Travel Writing: 2013*, Elizabeth Gilbert made this observation. “Here are two facts I learned long ago about travel writing: 1. There is no story in the world so marvelous that it cannot be told boringly. 2. There is no story in the world so boring that it cannot be told marvelously.” A travel narrative does not need to be about a European backpacking adventure or an African safari. You can tell an epic story about a drive to Pella, Iowa to see the tulips. You can weave a beautiful tale about a hike along a local lakeshore. If you want to take a look at some travel writing, consider the following:

- Bill Bryson’s *A Walk in the Woods* (1998)
- John Steinbeck’s *Travels with Charley: In Search of America* (1961)
- Cheryl Strayed’s *Wild: From Lost to Found on the Pacific Crest Trail* (2012)
- Jessica Bruder’s *Nomadland: Surviving America in the Twenty-First Century* (2017)

Food Narrative: Some of our most vivid moments involve food. Think of a favorite or least favorite recipe and weave your tale around the experience of making or eating that food. Some inspiring readings in this form include...

- Maya Angelou’s *Hallelujah! The Welcome Table: A Lifetime of Memories with Recipes* (2004)
- Lucy Kinsley’s *Relish: My Life in the Kitchen* (2013)
- Michael Gibney’s *Sous Chef: 24 Hours on the Line* (2015)

Interview: Interviews are rendered beautifully in *The New Yorker* magazine’s “Profiles” section. The author is often right there on the page next to the interview subject, reacting and perceiving. This is different than most other interview features in popular media.

Note that if all you do is write your questions and include the subject’s answers, the “creative” part of the essay is reduced to rubble. Describe your subject. How does she turn her head or blink when telling a funny story versus a sad one? What color pillows are on her couch, or what types of photos does she keep on her shelf? Place the reader into the setting, and don’t forget to use all five senses to take us there.

Go into an interview with a handful of questions prepared, but be open to unexpected gems every moment. Some of the best content can materialize from unexpected moments. The best question you can ask when you hear your subject say something interesting is, “Can you tell me more about that?” Be open. Be non-judgemental. Be very, very aware of your nonverbal signals, which will either keep your person talking or shut your person down.

Braided Essay: When a writer takes two or more different threads of thought and weaves them together in a single piece of nonfiction, that essay is braided. Go back to your brainstorming list from Chapter 1 and find two topics that might be tied together in some way. Sometimes they present themselves easily, and sometimes there is a distance that you get to bridge between paragraphs. The best way to see how braiding is done is to (say it with me here)...read some essays.

Here's an excerpt from [Issue 22.2 of Fourth Genre Magazine](#) in which the author, Nora Seilheimer, focuses on a single theme of fear, but braids fear of flying with fear of losing her husband to racial violence:

If you travel with a fear of flying, mental health experts recommend that you hold fast to the facts. Remind yourself of statistics that show that the most dangerous part of your travel day is the car ride to or from the airport. Remember that the chances of you being involved in a plane crash are one in three million. Don't let the media's recent focus on airline disasters condition you to believe that you're next. Take a deep breath. Fasten your seatbelt. Clear skies ahead.

If you're a mixed couple living with a fear of racial violence, Joe and I recommend holding fast to the facts as well, but don't get your hopes up. While you might interpret someone's microaggression accurately, or your injustice radar might turn your insides up to a boil, it's crucial that you stick to The Plan, the one you and your partner devised the second you realized it was too risky to keep loving each other without one. Here's Our Plan for reference:

Should a situation arise in which Joe is in danger, I will record everything on my phone, following suit of so many, too many Black mothers, sisters, wives, aunties, and friends. I will swipe up from the bottom of my locked screen the way Joe taught me so I don't lose time entering my six-digit security code. With my phone in hand, I will place my white body in front of Joe's Black body like a shield. I will let my white tears hit the ground like bombs. Joe will shapeshift. He will get small. He will make his six feet and three inches as close to invisible, impenetrable as possible. Joe won't say a word. Joe will keep breathing. He will keep breathing. Keep breathing. We won't let an endless video stream of authority figures murdering Black men condition either of us to believe that Joe is next because he's not he's not he is not next . . .

Read more about braided essays here: <https://writers.com/braided-essays>

Hermit Crab Essay: Hermit crabs wander around encasing themselves in whatever shield is readily available. The same is true for hermit crab essays. Wrap your story about an awkward first date in a private investigator's surveillance report. Tell about that creepy late-night encounter with a coyote from the perspective of the coyote. Check out the hermit crab essay in the "Voices and Truths" chapter written by Barb L'Heureux about the time she had new windows installed in her home.

Top Ten List: Made popular by David Letterman in the last decades of the twentieth century, a Top Ten List can probably be considered a sub-form under the Hermit Crab Essay. Instead of telling a straight, linear story about the last time you traveled with a toddler, write a top ten list of strategies to survive a long road trip with a toddler. By the end, your story is told in an unexpected form, and you have had some fun.

Good ol' Essay: We're not talking about a research paper. We're talking about those brainstorming lists you made of topics you're intrigued to learn more about and the deep dive you can take into exploring and presenting your newly gleaned knowledge in an exciting or sinister or humorous way. Here's a wonderful example of [an essay on pirates from Mark Hanna of Humanities Magazine](#):

Jailbreaks and riots in support of alleged pirates were common throughout the British Empire during the late seventeenth century. Local political leaders openly protected men who committed acts of piracy against powers that were nominally allied or at peace with England. In large part, these leaders were protecting their own hides: Colonists wanted to prevent depositions proving that they had harbored pirates or purchased their goods. Some of the instigators were fathers-in-law of pirates.

The best essays take something known and dig deeper in order to present the bigger picture, such as [this piece written by William Ferris on the cultural origins of singer Johnny Cash](#):

Five hundred white families were given farms of 20 to 40 acres that included a house, barn, privy, a mule, a cow, chicken coop, and food and supplies to support the family until they harvested their first crop. Each family cleared the land and cultivated their crops on it. In the winter of 1935, Ray and Carrie Rivers Cash moved into one of the homes with their children, one of whom was three-year-old Johnny Cash.

Essays that focus externally come with a similar set of ethics. The phrase “Research Paper” thumps our spirits with some trepidation, but it’s crucial to remember the rules of good research when writing an essay. I feel better about it when I reframe research and tell myself that I’m INVESTIGATING. A little shift to a CSI vibe changes my approach, but my responsibility to share truth remains. Find reliable sources and explain to your audience exactly why you trust them. Standard source citation may or may not be required by your instructor or audience, but you should still be crystal-clear with your audience about where you got your information. In this case, “creative” applies to the memorable way you present the new knowledge and the dominant impression you choose to convey.

How to choose your form? Just start writing. Get the story or information onto the page in rough draft or list form, and then decide how to shape it. Start with a basic essay form. As you continue to write, have some fun and try new forms. Consider what Truman Capote said in 1957 about the form an essay should take:

Since each story presents its own technical problems, obviously one can't generalize about them on a two-times-two-equals-four basis. Finding the right form for your story is simply to realize the most *natural* way of telling the story. The test of whether or not a writer has divined the natural shape of his story is just this: after reading it, can you imagine it differently, or does it silence your imagination and seem to you absolute and final? As an orange is final. As an orange is something nature has made just right (qtd in Hill).

This page titled [3: Bring Form to the Storm](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

4: Content

Answer the Journalist's Questions and Embrace the Et Cetera

The classic questions a journalist must answer for the reader are **who, what, when, where, how**—the creative side, then, might include **why**. According to Ballenger, it's the author's job to also include the **"So What?"** When we write for an audience, advises Ballenger, "the insights also have to be relevant to others. Though they may begin as an essayist's personal desire to understand himself or herself, the best essays ultimately transcend the small, self-interested world of the author and have something to say to someone else....the best essays ultimately arrive at someplace we all recognize—our struggles to love or feel at home with ourselves or find joy in what is extraordinary in otherwise ordinary things" (23).

"Write what you know," the teacher will tell you, and sometimes, the teacher will credit Mark Twain with having given that advice. He did, but not verbatim. He wrote about what he had done and where he had been, but he never explicitly said the words. Certainly start with what you know, but watch out for the limitations this advice will impose. Also write about what you don't know, but learn everything you can about it. Talk to people. Watch people. Read. Read some more. Gather what you learn and present it in a way that only you can, with your unique voice. Everything is material for creative nonfiction.

Author Jessica Handler offers the nonfiction writer permission to write about what's NOT there:

A dearth of facts can create a fertile space in the construction of a creative nonfiction narrative. Try considering, on the page, why you deem certain material important or where you and your narrative are without those facts. Tell the story of your research—its rewards, twists and turns, and dead ends. Write about the acts of myth-making and myth-uncovering. Write about what you *don't* know.

...I've faced that empty space in my own writing. Before my father died, he told me his great aunt had been buried in a coffee can under a hedge on his parents' lawn. This can't possibly be true for countless reasons, not the least of which is that she'd have to have been cremated, which isn't part of the Jewish burial tradition. I have no facts about my great-great-aunt other than a photo of her with a paper moon, probably on Coney Island. My grandmother and her brother are there, too—little kids then, long dead now. At first, this might seem to leave me with nothing to write about, at least not as nonfiction.

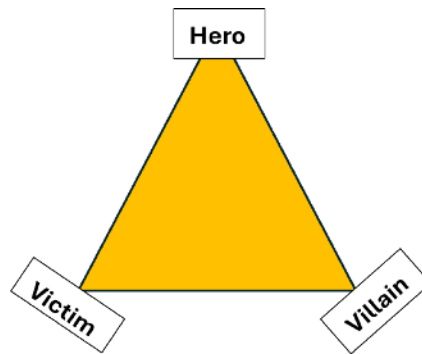
But I have so much. I have the fact of my father's belief in the coffee can story, and I know firsthand of his affection for his great aunt. I have what I know from my own experience about my father's penchant for strange stories and how I wish I could have seen Coney Island in its heyday. If I were brave enough, I could go to my father's childhood home and ask the strangers who live there now if I could search their hedge for an ancient coffee can. Someday, if I'm ever in the neighborhood, I might. That's a plot element right there, regardless of what I find—or don't find.

Instead of being limited by the missing facts, advises Handler, make the search part of the story. Investigate in every way. Go to the library. Call distant relatives. Search news archives. If the story still isn't complete, finish it with the tale of your own journey. "Creative nonfiction," celebrates Handler, "is a gloriously flexible genre. What we don't know or can't know doesn't have to wreck our writing. Instead, what seemed at first to be only an empty space can be an opportunity to shape and expand a narrative, exploring the gaps and writing our way through the myths."

Character

Casting your SELF accurately

The heading of this section is problematic. Accurately? Objectively? Maybe "Fairly" is better. Human tendency leans toward three jagged points of a triangular spectrum when writing about ourselves. We may see ourselves as the villain, making stupid choices when we should know better. Perhaps we see ourselves as the hero, making all the right moves as those around us flounder. Third, we see ourselves as the victim, being acted upon instead of acting. Any of those points may be correct, but the challenge of interacting with other humans is that our selves probably flop around in the middle of the triangle at any given moment. Further, what makes us a hero to some will make us a villain to others.



When writing about yourself, as you are likely to do in a nonfiction writing course, consider how you cast yourself as a character. Try to be fair. Write about mistakes you have made and what you have learned. Tell a story about a home run or a spelling bee championship. But try to balance the way you present yourself so your audience trusts you as a reliable narrator. One great way to gain perspective on an event you're writing about is to ask someone else who was part of that experience. For instance, "That day I won the school spelling bee in seventh grade, do you remember what I did when I won?" You may be picturing yourself as awkward, gangly. Your Aunt Jenny may remember you shaking hands with your fellow competitors in a gracious manner. How can you present a balanced picture for your reader?

Check out this link to explore more about self-perception as you figure out how to cast yourself as a character in your nonfiction writing:

<https://www.bustle.com/p/7-fascinating-ways-you-see-yourself-differently-than-others-see-you-15643306#:~:text=%22In%20general%2C%20people%20tend%20to,differently%20than%20others%20see%20them.>

Setting

Toni Morrison and Wallace Stegner, while celebrated for their fiction writing, were also prolific producers of nonfiction. They are both champions of setting.

A strong sense of place can bring dimension to a story or essay in a unique way. How much do you offer? Writer Brandi Reissenweber suggests, "Engaging setting starts with strong description. Focus on specific details that define the essence of the place and invite the reader to imagine it fully. Don't compartmentalize setting. Instead, lash description of place closely to the action."

One great example is a 1973 essay Toni Morrison wrote about a family cookout. Note the intertwining of movement and setting. By the end, the reader is sitting next to the family, waiting to eat some fish.

The fish were already awake, the potatoes were sliced and simmering next to the onions, and this whole tribal effort to have a day-long fish-and-cookout at Turkeyfoot Lake in honor of the eldest member of the Alabama wing of the family was beginning to draw Mama's and Aunt Millie's lips together in annoyance. For one thing, the Blue Gums (the Akron group of the family) thought Uncle Green belonged to them more than to us because they were more his age and remembered Alabama the way he did long before the migration North had begun: the first day the general store down home sold light-bread; the farm of 88 acres when it was prosperous and could feed 17 people year round; and other family reunions which were never ever called cook-outs in spite of the fact that they roasted corn and skewered fish over pine-cone fires on days just like this one.

The setting is the story in Stegner's essay entitled, "Finding the Place: A Migrant Childhood." Here's an excerpt:

The town grew around us, and incorporated us, and became our familiar territory: Main Street with its plank sidewalks, its drug and grocery and hardware stores, its pastime theatre, its lumberyard, its hotel and bank; Millionaire Row with its four our five bungalows with sweetpeas and nasturtiums in their yards; poverty flat where the two Chinese and metis had shacks (7).

Weather, flora, fauna, era, music, etc.

Reissenweber advises, "Not all stories demand that extensive attention to setting, but all writers need to be aware of how integral place is to the human experience. We don't just notice a place when we first see it and then forget about it entirely. Setting surrounds us, influences us, and we interact with it constantly. The same relationship should be true of our characters and their settings."

Morrison intertwines the setting with the movement in an essay about a family fishing trip. Stegner builds an entire narrative on the complex setting of a town that is a central character in his story. Both writers create momentum in different ways. In a more recent work, Katherine Boo constructs her setting in the prologue of her 2012 book, *Beyond the Beautiful Forevers*, a nonfiction narrative about a family living in a Mumbai slum. First, however, she creates an urgency that requires an understanding of the setting. Here's her opening sentence: "Midnight was closing in, the one-legged woman was grievously burned, and the Mumbai police were coming for Abdul and his father" (7).

Clearly, she has not begun the story at the beginning--see the notes on playing with narrative structure in Chapter 5--but she has opened with a powerful chunk of information that requires telling the reader what Abdul needs to do next. Here's how Boo gives us what we need to know in terms of setting just a couple of paragraphs later:

He cracked the door of the family Hut and looked out. His home sat midway down a row of hand-built spatchcock dwellings; the lopsided shed where he stowed his trash was just next door. To reach this shed unseen would deprive his neighbors of the pleasure of turning him in to the police. He didn't like the moon though: full and stupid bright, illuminating A dusty open lot in front of his home. Across the lot were the shacks of two dozen other families, and Abdul feared he wasn't the only person peering out from behind the cover of a plywood door. Some people in this slum wished his family ill because of the old Hindu Muslim resentments. Others resented his family for the modern reason, economic envy. Doing waste work that many Indians found contemptible, Abdul had lifted his large family above subsistence.

The open lot was quiet, at least--freakishly so. A kind of beachfront for a vast pool of sewage that marked the slums eastern border, the place was bedlam most nights: people fighting, cooking, flirting, bathing, tending goats, playing cricket, waiting for water at a public tap, lining up outside a little brothel, or sleeping off the effects of the grave-digging liquor dispensed from a hut two doors down from Abdul's own. The pressures that build up in crowded huts on narrow slum lanes had only this place, the *maidan*, to escape...

Now, among the feral pigs, water buffalo, and the usual belly down splay of alcoholics, there seemed to be just one watchful presence: a small, unspeakable boy from Nepal... (7)

The gravity of the moment is enhanced by the fragility of the setting, the easily-toppled structures and relationships, and the "stupid bright" moon. The journalistic questions are answered within the first three hundred words, and the next 164 pages create millions of dimensions upon each answer as the story evolves.

Audience

When writing in a classroom, you have a decent concept of your audience. You certainly know who is giving the grade. Whether you keep your prose to the classroom or submit it for a larger audience, a crucial ethical consideration is not to convey hate. You lose your audience immediately. Remember them and respect them.

Word choice and inner dialogue can land anywhere on a broad spectrum between connecting with a reader and alienating a reader. Granted, everyone who looks at your words, including the person assessing them for a grade, will see the message through their own lense of life experience. William Zinsser advises, "Don't try to visualize the great mass audience. There is no such audience--every reader is a different person." Do, however, write with compassion. Watch for hasty generalizations; watch for objectifying or reducing humans or populations. You can write authentically while still rendering yourself readable and gaining the trust of your audience.

Ethical Considerations

Truth, a concept that seems so concrete when we're younger, gets wobbly as we grow and share experiences with others. *New York Times* writer Megan O'Grady says this about our process of true storytelling: "The tenuous relationship between memory and imagination, once seen as a failing of the genre, becomes a kind of asset in this light: It takes not only truth but vision to counter

our culture's received ideas, to invent ourselves in our own way, on our own terms, against what Hartman calls 'the silence in the archives.'"

O'Grady observes the fluid nature of truth based on the lens through which an event is viewed. "The fantasy that you can say something so perfectly and with such absolute authority that it never needs another version told from another point of view, as my grandfather might have believed, is long over." As you dip your mind and hands into this genre, be ready for the inevitability of clashing memories. If even one other human is part of your story, the odds are strong that the other human remembers the events differently, anywhere on a spectrum from, "That never happened!" to, "That happened, but the horse was named Flynn, and your brother didn't shoot you with the bb gun on purpose."

When an audience reads nonfiction, they expect truth, notes Bruce Ballenger in his book, *Crafting Truth*. "We expect that the events that are described actually happened and that the writers' responses to these events are honest." Ballenger addresses the struggle of writing truth by introducing a spectrum of how the writer might get some aspect of the narrative wrong in the process of storytelling. He calls this "A Continuum of Lies," and advises the writer to decide where to draw the line on this continuum if we want to call our writing nonfiction. Here are Ballenger's "lies," listed in order of incongruity:

- Failure to remember a detail accurately
- Reconstructing dialogue
- Purposefully changing a detail
- Creating a composite character
- Making up something that didn't happen

Ballenger offers peace to the writer of nonfiction, suggesting that authors are "certainly interested in getting at the *emotional truth* of things, a deeply subjective and deeply personal perspective of things remembered that may transform them into scenes few others who were there might recognize" (4). The writer, he says, must make decisions throughout the creative process in terms of where to land on the continuum.

If I'm retelling the story of the time I hiked around Crater Lake in Oregon and I want to offer the detail of what species of trees grew along the rim of the lake, I will do a quick web search of common species of trees around Crater Lake so I can add that detail (see Natalie Goldberg's advice on giving things the "dignity of their names" in a later chapter). At the moment I grabbed one of those trees to keep from sliding down the slate and into the icy lake, I didn't say to myself, "I'm grabbing this Whitebark Pine." I probably just thought, *Holy Crap, don't slide into the glacial lake, you idiot*. A little research tells me that, based on the area of the lake in which I was hiking, the hardy little tree that saved me was probably Whitebark Pine. I may have it wrong. The tree may have been a cedar. That's OK with me. You, as a writer, will need to make those decisions at every turn in your journey of composing a story from memory.

The same goes with each of Ballenger's "lies," possibly until the last and most grisly on the list. If I want to paint a vivid picture of the last conversation I had with my older sister before she ran away from home when we were teenagers, I will probably not get the words exactly right since that happened in 1987. Will I get the emotional truth? From my viewpoint, yes. If I want to paint a picture with words describing the group of church ladies who descended upon my mother to help her after a grueling surgery when I was a little girl, can I create a composite character illustrating types of perfume, hairspray, and gigantic purses? That will be a decision I need to make in order to illustrate an emotional truth from that era. If I write that one of the church ladies smoked a joint in the back yard while listening to Led Zeppelin, I have crossed a line, because that didn't happen. Well, actually...that totally happened, but much later, and it wasn't a church lady. It was a neighborhood buddy of my brothers'...and a different story altogether.

Lee Gutkind, editor of the seminal magazine *Creative Nonfiction*, says this about the ethics of telling true stories:

There are very few rules for writers of creative nonfiction. You can predict the future, speculate about the past, or imagine what could have happened or what someone might have been thinking, as long as you don't violate the reader's trust, and in the process your own credibility. There are, however, limits to the freedom and flexibility that make creative nonfiction so attractive and compelling—legal, ethical, and moral issues that are challenging and, in many ways, impossible to clearly define. Freedom and flexibility—and daring—are governed by responsibility, not just to the people about whom we write, but to those who read and publish our work.

So, tell your truth. Do your best. Don't make up events. Recognize and make peace with the reality that others will recall the story differently. Tell your truth anyway. Remember O'Grady's observation that "Memory is also identity, and...seizing control of one's narrative has a particular power."

"Memory is a river. Memory is a pebble at the bottom of the river, slippery with the moss of our living hours. Memory is a tributary, a brackish stream returning to the ocean that dreamt it. Memory is the sea. Memory is the house on the sand with a red door I have stepped through, trying to remember the history of the waves.

In telling this story, I have followed my river all the way down to the sea, treading as closely as I could to my memory of the people, places, and events that shaped my life...May each of you find your way back to the water." —Safiya Sinclair, *Author's Note, How to Say Babylon*

This page titled [4: Content](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

5: Writing Standards

Concrete Content. “Creative” doesn’t have to mean “abstract.” The goal is still to offer a solid story and a vivid picture for your reader. If you are telling about a grumpy dog you had as a kid, watch out for the “grumpy” abstraction. This is where the rules of academic writing still apply: make a claim and offer evidence. Certainly describe your dog as “grumpy,” but make it concrete after that. Is it a facial expression, a sound he makes, the way he moves under the table every time you try to pet him?

Narrative Structure. A clear story has a set of important parts. You have probably seen this model when discussing story structure:

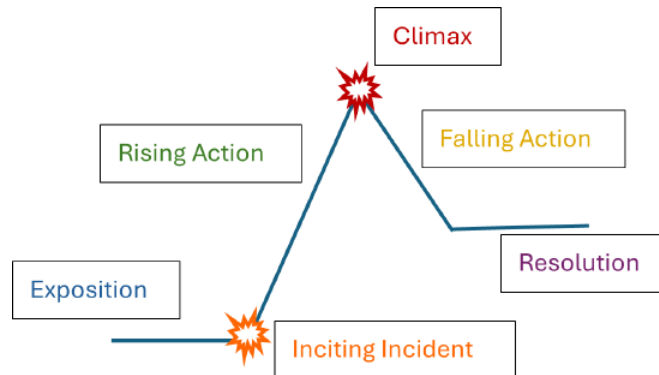


Figure 5.1: Freytag's Pyramid. (Copyright Sydney Heise)

This image is everywhere. Known as Freytag’s pyramid, it was conceptualized in the mid-nineteenth century by a German playwright and novelist named, surprisingly, Gustav Freytag. CITE THIS

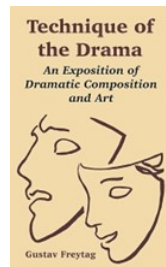


Figure 5.2: Technique of the Drama by Gustav Freytag.

Sean Glatch of writers.com notes that Freytag’s pyramid as a story structure is fairly universal, but most common in Western culture stories. He also acknowledges that the exact order in the diagram can be fluid. “Though some literary works break the traditional narrative structure of Freytag’s Pyramid or try to invert it, every story has a relationship to these five dramatic elements.”

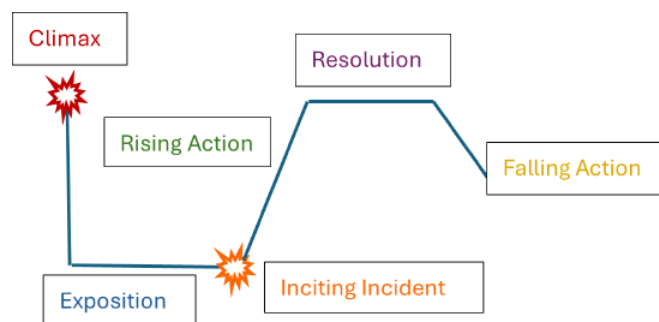


Figure 5.3: Nontraditional narrative structure (Copyright Sydney Heise)

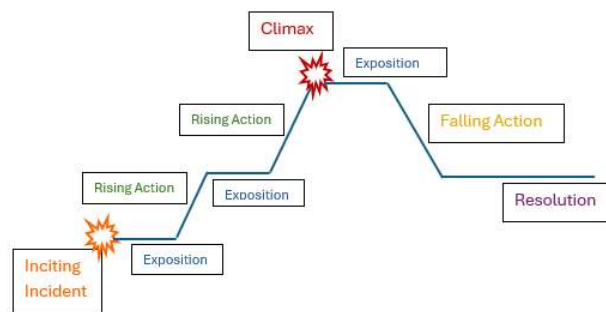


Figure 5.4: Nontraditional narrative structure (Copyright Sydney Heise)

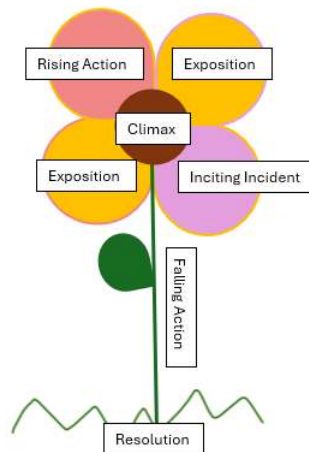


Figure 5.5: Nontraditional narrative structure (Copyright Sydney Heise)

Concise Wording

Watch out for beginning sentences such as “Now...” or, a favorite phrase of so many students when jumping into description: “I remember...” It’s implied that you remember because you’re writing the memory. Get rid of those opening words as you revise. Likewise, look out for modifiers such as “really, very, extremely, just...” Most college writing center websites have several suggestions for replacing “very ____” with a much more vivid descriptive word. Every word should have a job.

Recently retired managing editor of Random House publishing Benjamin Dreyer makes no secret of his disdain for modifiers like “very:”

For one thing, “very” is a fraud, masquerading as a strengthener when it merely wheedles and pleads. To call someone “brilliant” is to make a bold assertion; to call someone “very brilliant” attempts to persuade others of something one appears not to truly believe. Moreover, it’s a dull adverb and encourages duller adjectives. What, after all, is “very hungry” compared with “ravenous”? What’s “very sad” up against “despondent”? Who’d want to be “very strong” when you might be “herculean”?

Concise doesn’t always mean short. It means that every word on the page is crystal clear and is contributing to the meaning of the essay.

Some words have no meaning in various contexts. For instance, what does “things” mean?

Here are a few examples of the use of “things” in my own social media posts over the past five years. Note that each of these “things” could be replaced with more specific and concrete words that would enhance the meaning of the message.

Meetings are my least favorite -ings because I'm just not good at them. **Things** I am terrible at:

1. Maintaining attention on a task for more than 30 minutes.
2. Knowing when it's my turn to talk (stresses the heck out of me and always has).

3. Being nice to ANYONE for longer than 1 hour and ten minutes.
4. Cooperating.
5. Sitting still for longer than seven minutes.
6. Acting like a grown-up.
7. Keeping my language appropriate for any sustained time.

Some of my favorite -ings are: yelling, hiking, dancing, and singing. None of these go over very well in meetings.

Let's just be honest with each other: I'm not a great cook. I make a couple of **things** pretty OK, but nobody's dreaming of my culinary creations. I'm a robust chick because I'm really good at ordering out, not because I can cook. Anyway, I want to cook some chicken drumsticks. I try this about once every two years because I find them on sale and get all seduced by the cheapness, and I forget what a huge fail my last attempt was.

All the new **things** I have discovered and fallen in love with over the last 11 days:

~Peanut Butter Chex

~Zoey's Extraordinary Playlist (Hulu show)

~Kickboxing and ab workouts on Amazon Prime

~Painting the windows with liquid acrylic

~Kate DiCamillo (just kidding--I was already in love with her--but Sam has been reading one of her books to me, and it makes me laugh so much)

~Having my son read to me

Have **things** been awesome inside my head? Nope. But actually, lots of **things** have been pretty awesome.

Today was a really, really, really, really hard day. I told my Sweetheart. He showed up at my office with this stuff. Little **things** are big **things** sometimes. Interior violent storms still rage, but when I practice deep breathing, I can now smell roses. I sure love him. ("Interior violent storms" coined by Maya Angelou at the funeral of Coretta Scott King)

I'm learning some **things**. It seems that people living up on the bluffs are happy to live here, regardless of the weather. I couldn't get into my driveway today because the road slopes in front of our house and I slid right on by (even going super slow). Did some strategizing and eventually got in. We may have to say NO to some **things** this winter, because getting there and getting back is a different story for us than for others. And that might be the best **thing** to ever happen to me.

Dialogue. Can you do that? Yep, you absolutely can. **Find a nonfiction story with great dialogue. SEDARIS ON THE PLANE**

This page titled [5: Writing Standards](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

6: Artistry

The “Creative” part about Creative Nonfiction sometimes comes as you draft. More often, it shows up in the revision stage, after you have gotten the content onto the page. Here’s what Truman Capote told Pati Hill of *The Paris Review* about writing short stories. While he was talking about fiction at the time (1957, years before he jumped into nonfiction), it’s easy to see that he sought the same stylistic control in his later true stories.

CAPOTE

When seriously explored, the short story seems to me the most difficult and disciplining form of prose writing extant. Whatever control and technique I may have I owe entirely to my training in this medium.

INTERVIEWER

What do you mean exactly by “control”?

CAPOTE

I mean maintaining a stylistic and emotional upper hand over your material. Call it precious and go to hell, but I believe a story can be wrecked by a faulty rhythm in a sentence—especially if it occurs toward the end—or a mistake in paragraphing, even punctuation. Henry James is the maestro of the semicolon. Hemingway is a first-rate paragrapher. From the point of view of ear, Virginia Woolf never wrote a bad sentence. I don’t mean to imply that I successfully practice what I preach. I try, that’s all.

The sounds of writing—alliteration, assonance, consonance, rhythm.

The images—vivid description, all senses.

Figurative freedom in nonfiction—metaphor, simile, personification, symbolism.

A favorite metaphorical passage comes from [a letter Emily Dickinson wrote to an editor who asked for her photo to include with a poem he was publishing](#).

...the *Atlantic Monthly* editor, Thomas Wentworth Higginson, made a ...request [for a photo] to an obscure, retiring poet named Emily Dickinson who had written a letter asking if her verses “breathed.” Her response was much like Melville’s, if typically elliptical: “Could you believe me—without? I had no portrait, now, but am small, like the Wren, and my Hair is bold, like the Chestnut Bur—and my eyes, like the Sherry in the Glass, that the Guest leaves—Would this do just as well?”

Equally fun to read are [the words of writers describing their own colleagues using metaphor](#): “Virginia Woolf described him [Aldous Huxley] as ‘infinitely long’ and referred to him as ‘that gigantic grasshopper.’”

This page titled [6: Artistry](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

7: Openings and Closings

First Lines and Paragraphs

The best revision workshop I ever attended began like this: the professor walked in and said, “Open your draft notebooks.” We wrote with actual pens or pencils in spiral bound notebooks in those days. “Now,” said the professor, “Cross out the entire first paragraph. What is left is the way you should begin your essay.”

Sure enough, in nearly every case, my second paragraph was significantly more interesting than my first. It began with some movement, some feeling. The first paragraph was a warm-up for the real stuff. Of course, if your first paragraph offers some important exposition, dismantle that and tuck it into later parts of the essay. But if you can begin with movement or some compelling emotion, that essay is better.

I always tell my writing students that the job of the opening sentence is to reach out and embrace the reader into the essay. The job of the closing sentence/paragraph is to slap the reader in the face so they walk away feeling it. I also tell them that I NEVER settle on my opening OR closing sentences until I have completed the rest of the essay and revised it a few times. That first sentence is usually the last aspect of the essay I refine, and sometimes it's the very last piece of the essay I compose. This is where writing well in advance of deadlines can come in handy. Getting that piece written so it's swimming around in your psyche, jumping through neurons, bumping about in your lexicon...you get it, but I'm having fun picturing this...it's so helpful in the creative aspect of nonfiction writing. So many times, I wake up with the perfect first or last sentence jumping out of my mouth, and I must get it written immediately. This is also where the aforementioned “Storm Wall” idea comes in handy from our earlier chapter on brainstorming. I keep some sticky notes near my bed so I can scribble ideas as they occur to me and stick them right to the wall beside my bed.

Look through a publication of Creative Nonfiction magazine and collect a few first sentences in order to get a feel for your own best options. Take a look at these first sentences from a *Best American Essays* collection of 2017. Note how each one begins working toward an impression right away. They are all different lengths, different tones. Try a few different ways to begin your essay and workshop them with friends or classmates.

“There is a photo of you standing outside the house in Borough Park, grin wide, head back, laughing” (Resnick).

“If your body dies in Broward County, Florida, and nobody claims your body as the body of their next of kin, your body will be burned and disposed of by the Broward County Indigent Cremation and Disposition Program” (Notarnicola).

“These are banner times for penises on-screen” (Morris).

“Freddie Gray’s relatives arrived for the trial in the afternoon, after the prep-school kids had left” (Jackson).

Drawing the Curtain on Your Essay: Closing the Story

Here’s an interesting question: If you’re writing about yourself, and you are presumably still alive, how do you know when or how to end it when the story didn’t really end yet?

The best way to end a personal essay is to tell your audience what you make of the experience. Ballenger calls it the “So What” of the piece. He suggests asking yourself this question about an essay you’ve produced: “What I understand now about this that I didn’t understand then is...” (35). This generally addresses the answer to the “So What?” question Ballenger suggests answering.

For instance, if I were to continue the essay rooted in my inspiration from an earlier prompt in which I remembered my tendency as a child to ride cardboard boxes down staircases, so what? How did this habit play out in other aspects of my life? Did I do it because I enjoy taking risks, going fast, or crashing into cement walls? Was it a metaphor for my later choices, or did I learn what I needed to learn from my cardboard box experiences? A great way to end any essay is to make sense of your experience (or the experience of someone else) through your own current lens.

The UNC-Chapel Hill writing center delivers solid advice on concluding your essay. First, they reinforce Ballenger’s advice using the “So What” strategy. Tell your audience why they should care. Other strategies include:

- Save an especially cool insight or quote for the end. Don’t open a whole new topic, but hold onto some amazing words that synthesize the story you’re telling and slap them in that final paragraph.

- If you're writing about a problem, suggest steps toward a solution or further investigation.
- Remind your audience of an image or action you used in your introduction. This strategy plays an exciting role in getting the audience's brain to step back to the intro and replay your entire message.

Developmental Editor Katie Bannon observes that the conclusion is often where she sees a nonfiction essay, especially memoir, fall flat. Here's what she suggests to keep your ending from feeling cliché or abrupt:

What's most important for an ending is that the reader understands how the character of "you" has changed. That might involve an external shift—you've moved, ended a bad relationship, kicked an addiction—but most importantly, it should involve an *internal* shift – a deeper level of self-understanding than the character had at the beginning. While there should be a sense of resolution at the end, that doesn't need to mean that everything is picture perfect. Tidy or moral endings often ring hollow to readers. The best endings leave us satisfied that there has been a change, without tying things up too neatly.

Other conclusion content to avoid...

- summarize your content (insulting to your readers),
- toss irrelevant information into the final paragraph (confuses the readers),
- give self-righteous advice (also insulting—let readers draw their own conclusion), or
- wait until the final paragraph to make your actual point (readers will have stopped reading by then if they don't get what you're trying to say)
- above all, no matter what, never, NEVER begin that concluding paragraph with "In Conclusion." Your audience will understand that you're ending the essay based on the cessation of text on the page.

Consider these closing paragraphs from some favorite essayists as you figure out how to wrap up your own creative pieces.

Here's a concluding paragraph from a 2012 *Atlantic* article about tourist kidnappings in Egypt:

Shortly after my tea with Attwa, two more Americans and their guide were taken hostage. At first, this safari seemed different. The kidnapper, a 32-year-old truck driver, threatened to hold the hostages until his uncle (who he said had been arrested after refusing to bribe the police) was freed from prison. Four days later, however, he released them, unharmed. "We were treated just like they treat their own," the hostages' translator told a reporter. The kidnapper explained that in addition to the customary tea and coffee, he had served his guests roast lamb, a dish usually reserved for special occasions. He said his uncle remained in prison (Topol).

While the Topol article told an external-focused story, David Sedaris shared his experiences with European socialized medicine. Here's how he ends his story:

I've gone from avoiding dentists and periodontists to practically staking them, not in some quest for a Hollywood smile but because I enjoy their company. I'm happy in their waiting rooms, the coffee tables heaped with Gala and Madame Figaro. I like their mumbled French, spoken from behind Tyvek masks. None of them ever call me David, no matter how often I invite them to. Rather, I'm Monsieur Sedaris, not my father but the smaller, Continental model. Monsieur Sedaris with the four lower implants. Monsieur Sedaris with the good-time teeth, sweating so fiercely he leaves the office two kilos lighter. That's me, pointing to the bathroom and asking the receptionist if I may use the sandbox, me traipsing down the stairs in a fresh set of clothes, my smile bittersweet and drearied with blood, counting the days until I can come back, and return myself to this curious, socialized care (Sedaris).

This page titled [7: Openings and Closings](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage

Frank McCourt's *Angela's Ashes* is often credited with igniting the rocket of memoir popularity in the 1990s. The memoir won the Pulitzer Prize, the National Book Award, and a top spot on the *New York Times* best-seller list. Since then, memoir in general has continued to rise as a popular genre. Stories about difficult or unconventional childhood experiences tend to gain the most attention, but some writers, such as David Sedaris, make a living selling revised journal entries dripping with flippant observations about everyday wanderings and interactions mixed with the inevitable heartbreaks in life. He shares everything from moments spent feeding wildlife in his backyard to gathering with his family after the suicide of his sister.

Celebrity memoirs have seized a top spot on nonfiction best-seller lists, and their popularity has exploded in recent years. The Obamas reportedly received a 60 million dollar advance from their publisher for two memoirs describing their years in the White House. Barack Obama's 2020 book entitled *A Promised Land* set a record for the highest nonfiction book sales on its first day of publication, selling 887,000 copies (Porterfield). That record didn't hold on long, though, as Prince Harry's *Spare* set a new record in 2023, selling over a million copies worldwide on its first day of release. Harry reportedly made "only" a 20 million dollar advance from Penguin/Random House for his novel, about which he has been transparent that he used a ghostwriter named J.R. Moehringer. **Both books continue to sell.**

Behind-the-scenes stories of popular celebrity lives are hot in the 2020s. Britney Spears, Elliot Page, Trevor Noah, and Matthew Perry have **penned** books—whether by themselves or with the help of ghost writers, the public will not know.

Other memoir nonfiction books with themes such as gender differences, environmental awareness, and cultural navigation that have sold well in the past five years include *Braiding Sweetgrass*, *Crying in HMart*, and *Educated*.

As of May 2025, Robin Wall Kimmerer's *Braiding Sweetgrass* was still number six on the *New York Times* paperback nonfiction bestseller list, having ranked near the top for 263 weeks ("Bestsellers—Paperback Nonfiction"). An exploration that combines storytelling from her indigenous culture (Dr. Kimmerer is a member of the Potawatomi Nation) with her own experiences as a botanist and a mother, *Braiding Sweetgrass* is also a perfect long-form example of the braided essay explained in a later chapter on nonfiction forms. The braided form is exposed to the reader even in the subtitle of the book, *Indigenous Wisdom, Scientific Knowledge, and the Teachings of Plants*.

Here's an excerpt:

We have enjoyed the feast generously laid out for us by Mother Earth, but now the plates are empty and the dining room is a mess. It's time we started doing the dishes in Mother Earth's kitchen. Doing dishes has gotten a bad rap, but everyone who migrates to the kitchen after a meal knows that that's where the laughter happens, the good conversations, the friendships. Doing dishes, like doing restoration, forms relationships. How we approach restoration of land depends, of course, on what we believe that "land" means. If land is just real estate, then restoration looks very different than if land is the source of a subsistence economy and a spiritual home. Restoring land for production of natural resources is not the same as renewal of land as cultural identity. We have to think about what land means (328).

Braiding Sweetgrass, the second of four books written by Kimmerer, is a superb example of contemporary creative nonfiction, full of powerful narrative, strong sensory description, memorable metaphor (as in the dishwashing comparison above), and gentle rhetorical face-punches.

TRANSITION HERE

Veracity has been a fraught topic in recent decades as a few mega-hit nonfiction books have been slammed for inaccurate information. Frank McCourt was verbally attacked on a European talk show by a man claiming to have grown up in Limerick, the town McCourt portrayed in *Angela's Ashes*, his 1997 Pulitzer-Prize winning memoir. The perspiring audience member called McCourt a liar, claiming gross exaggeration throughout the book (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-Mb8Mb0p808>). James Frey was famously skewered in 2006 by Oprah Winfrey for fabricating several events and characters in his best-seller, *A Million Little Pieces*. In 2011, the mega-hit book entitled *Three Cups of Tea* by Greg Mortenson was scrutinized by fellow writers, not only for

the truth of the events described, but for the way Mortenson was reportedly mishandling funds that had been donated to help the people in Afghanistan he claimed to serve.

Read more about the Mortenson debacle: <https://www.npr.org/sections/thetwo-way/2011/04/18/135508982/three-cups-of-tea-author-in-hot-water-over-alleged-fabrications>

McCourt's Questions: <https://www.irishpost.com/entertainment/angelas-ashes-7-things-may-not-know-pulitzer-prize-winning-memoir-author-169766>

James Frey's story: <https://www.history.com/this-day-in-history/oprah-winfrey-takes-james-frey-to-task-for-lying>

Research nonfiction: Erik Larsen. Jon Krakauer. Began in this era with Capote spending two years in the town the crime occurred. "Literary Nonfiction."

This page titled [8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

9: Voices and Truths

Some of the best writing I have read came from my own students and friends. I teach at a two-year technical college, not a place known for its presence in the world of creative writing. Some of these pieces came from journal prompts; others, from assignments on structure; still others came from a strong need to record their experiences in order to make sense of life. All of them are authentic, beautiful voices expressing their truths.

[9.1: Bad Ass](#)

[9.2: The Crabby Contractor](#)

[9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?](#)

[9.4: In Sight of Myself](#)

This page titled [9: Voices and Truths](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Lisa Heise](#).

9.1: Bad Ass

Here's an essay written by Chris Gough, a former Creative Nonfiction student. Notice the vivid description and clear storyline. It's not about any big tragedy or accomplishment—it's a story about the day-to-day of working in a salon.

Back in the early nineties, I worked as a receptionist in a beauty salon with twelve hairdressers. My job was more than just making appointments for cuts, curls, and colors. I did sales and purchases of the various beauty products sold. Goopy creams that smelled like my doctor's office, shampoo with the ocean breeze of a coconut, and hairspray stronger than cement, were all sold at the front desk. I collected chair rental from the reluctant beauticians every Friday. I washed and folded towels, fighting with overflowing laundry bins and static zaps from the hot dryer. The overall appearance of the salon and making sure it looked good, had been another of many of my duties. The most important job tasked to me was pampering the women who came in once or twice a week for what was termed a *standing* appointment. All I ever asked in return was a piece of their story, to learn the details of their history. I learned quickly; their stories were no different than mine. To think, up until that moment, I feared old people.

A standing appointment meant a woman, usually an older woman from a generation gone by, coming in for a hairdo on the same day at the same time each week. To get your hair set was a big deal to the women who came in. It was more of a social gathering than anything. Some came twice a week and those, who perhaps had a smaller budget, came in once. They would get a deep cleaning, followed by rollers tightly secured to the scalp, thirty minutes or so blasted with extreme heat, and the final step, the comb-out. The comb-out always looked incredibly painful as the beautician grabbed clumps of hair with one hand and with a comb in the other, proceeded to violently backcomb or tease it all into what can only be described as a rat's nest. Thin wisps of grey and faded hair stood straight in the air slightly curled at the top. Each clump would be sculpted with precision in place like an artist molding clay. With a can of Aqua Net, the beautician would spin the ladies around in the chair and just spray for a good minute to insure the newly coifed do would not be doing anything but staying perfectly in place until they met again. By the end of the day my lips were coated with shellac from walking through an Aqua Net haze for eight hours. The taste of stale alcohol hung on the back of my tongue and tonsils. During the height of coifed hair season, the holidays, my nostrils would become stuck from breathing in the effervescence over the course of the day.

The most crucial part of my job had been knowing who took cream and who did not in their coffee. For those who did, I knew what shade their coffee needed to be. Some ladies liked a cold Coke from the vending machine and without being asked, I had it waiting for them by their dryer with their favorite magazine. For those that were there for a duration, I would take their lunch order and walk to the small bakery two doors down and get their lunch.

North Breezes House of Beauty was a buzz of excitement. Most beauticians worked Tuesday through Saturday. Tuesdays were busy enough to keep the day moving. Wednesday always went fast with the dread of Thursday pressing on you. Thursday was the day everything happened. I had to be sharp and ready for anything. Ladies would show up fifteen minutes late and then begged their hairdresser for a perm at the last minute.

"My hair would set better and Jenny is having a dinner party on Sunday. You don't mind, do you?"

Of course, her request was obliged. This meant for the next twenty minutes everything I should be doing came to a halt. I needed to call the next three ladies in line at home. I would explain that Bonnie wanted to know if they could come in thirty minutes earlier or would they want to switch until tomorrow. If the lady grumbled a bit, Bonnie lured her with the promise of getting her grey hairs colored a much-needed week earlier, if she accepted the offer. It had been nothing but wheeling and dealing in that place.

It never failed of the twelve beauticians that worked there nine of them always overbooked on Thursdays. It was a constant juggle of keeping everyone moving in and out, as well as keeping everyone happy while they waited endlessly to get their turn in the chair. The pouring of coffee, a fresh pot brewed every ten minutes and stains wiped up off the laminated end tables kept me running. The beauticians were divas in their own right. They needed me to help rinse harsh astringent chemicals out of someone's head, find rollers for perms and basically wipe their ass because they made the magic happen.

I lived for the brief moments where I went to hide in the back room. The washer and dryer were kept there; it had been the same room as the employee break room. The only place where a client dared not enter and break the sanctity of my five minutes of peace and quiet. I used those five minutes wisely. I would light up my cigarette, take the dry towels out and fold them while puffing between folds. By the time my last puff came, the next load of towels was in the washing machine and the timer set for sixty minutes on the dryer. About the time when I would need another break.

Friday was a rinse and repeat of Thursday, only dialed down a bit. Most of the clients who came in were clients who came faithfully every six weeks for a cut and style. They would leave the chair full of beauty and confidence. A smile crossed their face. The way they tilted their head and turned side to side, said it all.

Saturdays were the best. On average only half of the beauticians worked on Saturdays. Those that did were more than likely to be a tad and I mean just a tad bit hung over from the night before. I know this to be true because four of the six that worked and including myself almost always went out together on Friday nights. We would pitch in Saturday morning and buy breakfast from the German Bakery two doors down. My favorite was the oatmeal. I loved how the steam would roll out of the cup up towards my puffy face and make it all feel better.

I loved my job. The pay sucked, but the perks like a free lunch, little gifts, and all the free hairstyles a girl could ever want, made up for no health insurance, no paid vacation and living by the seat of my pants trying to make ends meet. It was my first job in years where it was socially acceptable to wear high heels for three days out of the week. That job made me feel important.

The women treated me well for all my doting. At Christmas, I was flooded with gifts and cash. Sometimes while taking their lunch order, they told me to get something for myself. One lady brought me small tokens throughout the year to show her appreciation.

What kept me going back every day for over three years, had to have been the women who came in every week. I loved to hear their gossiping about one another while under the hood of the dryer. They all were hard of hearing and the noise of the dryer had them almost yelling while talking to one another. It was hard not to listen. The stories were of times long since passed and as recent as the Saturday before. A good mix of who drank too much at the New Year's Party, and who was acting like a two-bit hussy at the children's fundraiser. My favorite gossip, had been who was sleeping with who.

"Did you see Jean last night? She obviously had too much to drink." Said Mrs. So and So.

"I heard she slept with Bill last night. You know Barbara is out of town visiting the kids?" Mrs. Busy Body added.

There was one lady who kept her lips pursed. None of the mightier-than-thou women would give her the time of day. A few would look down their noses at her. Mrs. McCandliss was a tough old broad. She never talked with the mightier-than-thou women while sitting in the smoking section waiting for her turn in the chair. She held her head high under the dryer and flipped through her magazine for forty minutes with disgust. It had been hard to tell if it had been the nineties fashion that upset her in Vogue magazine, or the conversations she overheard from the women sitting around her.

She was hard to get to know and held her secrets close, divulging only what she deemed necessary. I respected her bravado. She was, in my eyes, a bad ass. I tried to win her over and learn more about her back story but she left me with nothing but my imagination.

Mrs. McCandliss was a fashion statement all to herself. She always wore leopard skin leggings, before leggings were even a thing. Her chicken legs connected to her robust torso which she covered with bedazzled shirts that never made any sense.

Every week I waited on her hand and foot. I made sure to show the other women how much time I spent on her. She was somebody too. Her favorite dryer was always ready with a cold coke and a clean ashtray. I would try and make small talk only to be answered with a simple yes or no. Her voice sounded like the cracking of an old leather jacket on a chilly fall night.

The salon kept umbrellas up by the front door for those rainy days to help the women out to their cars so as not to deflate their coif. My job required me to be at the ready as they approached the front door. With one hand holding the door open and the other pushing the release button on the umbrella, I would escort them out to their cars.

One rainy Thursday, Mrs. McCandliss was preparing to leave. I took it as fate. I would escort her out to her car in the pouring rain under the protection of the umbrella. This would be my chance to make gains in our relationship. Perhaps she might have something to say without the ears of the other women to cast judgement. Perhaps a morsel of back story. She approached the front door while lighting her cigarette. With umbrella in hand, I opened the door. She just crossed the threshold as I pushed the button releasing the large umbrella. To my dismay, Mrs. McCandliss continued past me and proceeded to walk into the rain towards her car. Not daunted; I quickly followed.

"Mrs. McCandliss, wait. You don't want to ruin your hair, do you?" I exclaimed jumping over puddles.

In one long drag of her cigarette, she consumed half of her smoke. She flung the remaining half a good five feet into the air. The sizzle of it hitting the rain-soaked pavement caused me to stop in my tracks. Her leopard skin legs kept moving and without turning

back she gave me what I had been chasing for all that time, a piece of her. One of her hidden secrets.

“Honey, only two things melt in the rain, and I ain’t made of either of ‘em.” She kept walking.

“What’s that Mrs. McCandliss?” I was so eager.

“Sugar and shit.”

My entire body deflated. Standing in the pouring rain my brain tried to register what just transpired. I walked back into the salon soaked. My hair hung on my face like wet strands of yarn. Inside the salon, the mightier-than-thou women all laughed. They saw it coming.

“I could have told you that.” Mrs. Baxter laughed as I slumped down at my desk soaked like an overcooked lasagna noodle.

The mightier-than-thou women finished laughing then quickly reassured me it was not me but Mrs. McCandliss and her mean old stubbornness. Crushed and embarrassed, I continued with the rest of my day. However, the following week came and with it came Mrs. McCandliss for her standing appointment. She offered no apologies or remorse for her behavior. To her it was just another day, business as usual. When I brought her a refill on her Coke while she sat under the hood of the dryer, she looked up to me and gave the tiniest hint of a smile as she thanked me for the Coke. I took it for what it was. An old woman who, for whatever reason, held her secrets close. Perhaps she was a private person. Perhaps her life had been hard and through the course of it, it hardened her too. Whatever the reason, in my mind she still had my respect; she was still a bad ass.

This page titled [9.1: Bad Ass](#) is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Chris Gough](#).

9.2: The Crabby Contractor

Here's a great example of a hermit crab essay. Again, it's about a day-to-day event: getting new windows. The author, former student Barb L'Heureux, tells the story in the form of various memos from the contractors.

5/5/24 - Good afternoon, Ms. Jingleheimer Schmidt—may I call you Joan Jacob? As I mentioned when you hired me, I will be making periodic reports to you about the progress of your home remodeling project. To this end, I have hired many subcontractors for different aspects of the process. Corraling these workmen and women as we move forward remains my service to you. Please hold all questions until the end.

5/6/24 – Umm. We will be needing keys to your home and garage to move forward.

5/7/24 – The basement “excavation” began this morning. A front-loader would come in handy as the quantity of stuff (i.e., junk) staggered the crew enlisted to bring a semblance of order to this area. If one man’s junk is another’s treasure, you might make a bundle with all we safely remove from your cellar. Moving the majority of unused items (yes, there are still price tags on many) to a storage unit, we hope to interest the HGTV team that produces “Garage Sales Wars.” Our professional opinion of this aspect of your remodel seems convinced that your stuff—at night—indeed multiplies in the dark.

5/9/24 – According to Louis Parrish, esteemed psychiatrist, and author of **Cooking as therapy: How to keep your soufflé up & your depression quotient down**: “If you can organise your kitchen, you can organise your life.” If I may be frank, your kitchen organization tends toward *Early Modern Mess*. While we realize and accept that cooking lies at the bottom of your many household skills, we also deem it important to find a place for everything and attempt at keeping everything in its place. Storing dishes and silverware in hanging mesh bags for the wash, rinse, and sanitize method of your childhood Girl Scout training lacks promise for your plan to entertain more friends and family in said kitchen. To that end as well, our kitchen expert plans for the installation of a sink, multiple cabinets, counters, a table and chairs, and a refrigerator of a more recent vintage where the freezer does not remain within the main area but has a door of its own. Have you considered a subscription to a meal kit company? There are limits to the quantity of frozen meals one ought to keep.

5/12/24 – May I use the word “appalled” when describing the chaos found in your bedroom by the crew in there? Yes, many internet influencers suggest the floodrobe method of keeping one’s clothes handy without the task of using drawers for folded clothes and a closet with a rod for hanging clothes requiring less unwrinkledness. We suggest bucking that trend and getting up to speed with the idea that the bedroom floor is not a storage space for clothes. At the very least, acquiring a treadmill that fits in your master bedroom will provide a starting place for you to learn the value of hanging things up.

5/15/24 – Your paper filing system stinks. In this day of computers with large storage capacities, you no longer need to print all your bills, invoices, and payment history. The team we hired to sort through this mountain of paperwork nearly fainted, collectively, when your office was breached. Indeed, we rented a catapult to assail the dis-order. We find no need to retain checkbook stubs from the last thirty years of your life. They can be tossed. Likewise, receipts for bills paid and invoices for items purchased in that same time frame serve no rational purpose and demand disposal. While we laud your intention to store your entire library of books within the two shelves in the office, we suggest a winnowing process as well as an organizing system—such as by topic or alphabetically by author—that no longer relies on grouping by height and then by color. Stability and safety demand no less.

5/22/24 – Only one project remains, Ms. Jones: the bathroom. Surely a more personal space exists not. Our subcontractor suggests two major changes: a tub/shower combination and a small under-sink cabinet for keeping items such as toilet paper and toiletries. While one might remember to grab another roll of the former from the storage shed in the yard before a more urgent need comes forth, one might not remember, and potty chaos ensues.

We recognize that sponge baths do have a certain cachet—leftover from the afore-mentioned Girl Scout days—they also do, however, lack the joy, tactile experience, and cleanliness that a tub or shower provide. While not found in the Bible or other religious texts, we all know from some corner of our childhoods that cleanliness is next to godliness. No doubt deodorant and cologne cover many an odor. We feel certain also that you—in your deepest well—desire not to offend anyone olfactorarily.

6/3/24 – Our job here is done. We all have striven to provide you with a home both functional and fun. It was Wendell Berry who said “[Don't own so much clutter that you will be relieved to see your house catch fire.](#)” While at first glance, many of us wondered

if that method of clutter management might be more expeditious, over time, each independent worker began to see the trees for the forest of your abode. Much time was spent in contemplation of creating beauty and function from the haphazard form of your previous style of living. Indeed, the challenge captured our collective imaginations. We hope that installing several windows might also connect you to the world outside your home, the world of other people and nature.

And finally, speaking of nature, dealing with your four-legged, furry creature—we debated whether it be dog, cat, or wild creature—might demand another contract soon. It provides a challenge that none of us currently has the currency to consider.

A bill for our many services will be sent within a week and payment is expected within thirty days to a month. Please be sure to like us on Facebook, Instagram, X (formerly known as Twitter), and other social media sites. Word of mouth works wonders.

With gratitude and sincerity, your mother.

This page titled [9.2: The Crabby Contractor](#) is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Barb L'Heureux](#).

9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?

This narrative of an unlikely marathon runner written by Casey Crookston is a great example of a solid storyline with occasional flashbacks throughout. He uses clear signposts and tells his story completely, but the order of events is presented in a way that mixes exposition throughout. Here, the author's authentic narrative voice illustrates William Zinnser's writing advice from On Writing Well: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it."

The starting gate near the Minneapolis Metrodome was a mass of humanity. Ten thousand people crowded together and waited for 8:00 AM to arrive. I was shivering, but not from the October cold. There was a collective sense of shared purpose and friendship, a unity among thousands of total strangers. We were all here to push the limits of our own physical and mental abilities, and I basked in the thrill of being a part of it.

While waiting to start I took mental snapshots of the other marathoners around me. Next to me was a man in his 50's chatting easily with a young woman in her 20's. They wore matching yellow shirts. In hand-written black ink, hers said "Cheer for my dad" and his said, "Cheer for my daughter". They were more than father and daughter. They were friends, and I imagined all their training together and how bonding it must have been.

Behind me was a group of young twenty-something college boys. They looked bright-eyed and healthy, clean cut with clean language. Instead of spending their free time drinking, smoking and being idle, they had spent it training for a marathon.

To my right was a stooped, gray-haired man with a thick beard and a bent back. He looked like something out of a Walt Whitman poem and his bib indicated he was over eighty years old. I asked him what his time goal was, and in a raspy voice aged by years and experience, he replied slowly, "I just want to cross the finish line" and then he showed me a crooked-toothed smile. Everywhere, all around me, there were thousands of marathoners with excitement in their eyes. Each of them had a story and a history that brought them to this place on this day. I wished I could know them all.

A booming voice over a PA counted down the minutes, then the seconds. At 8:00 AM a horn sounded and a crescendoing cheer rose up and filled the air and gave me goosebumps. We jumped, clapped, laughed, slapped each other on the back and wished 'good luck' to total strangers. Slowly, the mass of runners began to roll forward.

My first marathon had begun.

"If you don't do something about your blood pressure," the doctor said, "you are going to die young."

I was thirty-eight years old, sixty-five pounds overweight, and woefully out of shape. I knew he was right. I'd known it for years, but hearing the prediction of my early death was perhaps the catalyst. I immediately began a modest exercise program and paid more attention to what I ate. Almost without trying I dropped fifteen pounds.

But then I plateaued. Hard.

I shook up the exercise program a little and tried a few fad diets, all with no real results. I stayed at the plateau. I laid in bed at night imaging myself as skinny, fit and in shape. I looked at my rotund body in the mirror and tried to see the skinny, muscular me inside all those rolls. I knew he was in there, I just needed to bring him out. My current level of activity and diet had started off well, but it was not going to lose those last fifty pounds.

I needed a plan. I needed a goal. I need a challenge.

Whatever I decided to do, it had to be affordable and it had to be realistic. Climbing Mt. Everest or becoming an Olympic athlete were not options. But I also knew it would need to be a serious, demanding, life-altering challenge. After mentally sifting through a multitude of options and ruling them out as either too easy or too impractical, I eventually settled on the one thing I'd told myself a hundred times I absolutely would never do, could never do. It had always been beyond my capability. Out of my reach. Impossible.

When I told my wife I was going to run a marathon, she literally laughed out loud. Then she saw the look in my eyes and stopped laughing.

"Oh honey," she said softly, "Have you really thought about this?"

On the morning of the marathon, I awoke at five a.m. feeling well rested and calm. I could hear my father already stirring downstairs. He and my mom had flown in from Utah, and my sister and her two kids had come from Texas. They were here to offer moral support, and for that, I was profoundly grateful. They'd announced their plans to come months earlier when I'd been in the early stages of training, and although nobody ever said so out loud, I suspect their ulterior motive in coming was to keep me from backing out before the marathon. I didn't mind. In fact, it made me love them all the more.

I dressed and ate in the dark of a house still mostly sleeping, and was surprised at the peace I felt. On the pre-sunrise drive, I chatted with my dad and told him how on a few occasions during the training I'd felt the unmistakable influence of inspiration and divine guidance. It was a calm, peaceful drive and a good visit with my father.

The Metrodome in Minneapolis was filled with marathoners all with numbers pinned to their shirts or shorts. I glanced around at the different shapes, sizes, and ages. Some looked like hardcore runners: small, rail thin, wiry muscles, probably one or two percent body fat, almost unhealthy looking but no doubt fast. Some looked like professional athletes: muscular and well toned. Others, I was relieved to see, looked normal. I was grateful for the normal people who eased my feelings of being an impostor.

I tried to ignore the thoughts that I was an intruder, that I didn't belong. Even among the normal people, not many shared my body shape.

It had been seven months since I'd made the decision to run a marathon, the last six of which I'd jogged over five-hundred miles in preparation. I'd lost a few pounds in the process, I'd gone from a tight size 40 to a comfortable 38, and the doctor was amazed at how far my blood pressure had dropped, but I nonetheless still had a very un-marathon esque physique and was still a good forty-five pounds overweight. A few of the hardcore runner types noticed me, looked for the race number I had pinned to my shorts, and then politely tried to hide their surprise. Or maybe it was it skepticism.

I've earned the right to be here. Six months and five hundred miles of training. I belong. I repeated this to myself more than once.

On the walk from the Metrodome to the starting gate, I struck up a short conversation with a man who was about to run his tenth marathon. I told him it was my first.

"So your goal is just to finish, right?" he asked me. "No time you are trying to hit?"

I told him that I really wanted to finish in time to get a medal, and he was quick to rebuke me.

"Don't!" he said. "All you want to do is cross that finish line, and if you do, it will be a great first marathon."

He was right. It was a point my first-time training book had repeated endlessly. From the long training runs on Saturdays, I knew that finishing all 26.2 miles within the six hours required to medal was going to be a hard slog. I knew this. But of course, being human I still really wanted that medal. I'd told myself before, and again now, that crossing the finish line was the only goal for today, and that time was not important.

Just cross that line. Finish. 26.2 miles. Do not stop.

The first eight miles went by quickly. The streets were lined with people cheering and waving homemade signs. Little kids stood with their hands out and were delighted when passing runners gave them high-fives. I always did. As we passed the Basilica of St. Mary, an impressive, towering cathedral on the edge of downtown, her bells were ringing in full force in honor of the runners, filling the air with powerful music which I felt in my bones.

It was magical. It was fun.

The old guy with a crooked back and gray beard jogged next to me for a while and we made a little small talk but mostly we just focused on jogging. We went up a hill and he slowed down. I fell in for a while with a group wearing matching Team Mayo Clinic shirts. One of them, a man in his late sixties, was shuffling along easily and had not broken a sweat. This was his 70'th marathon, and he loudly and happily gave courage, advice, and cheer to anyone who would listen. He'd developed a following. A younger member of Team Mayo Clinic, maybe about my age, looked fit and in shape but the expression on his face told me he was struggling. Later, much later, I would watch him drop out.

Around mile ten I could feel myself start to slow down. I was not concerned, yet. I knew from my long runs that this would happen.

Mile twelve. The crowd of runners was thinning out. Fatigue was setting in. My lungs began to ache and my legs were tired. I no longer moved to the side of the road to high-five the hands of little kids. Only two miles until mile fourteen where my family would be waiting.

The halfway clock at 13.1 was my first indication that I was behind time if I wanted to medal. I was a few minutes under three hours, and I knew the back half would be slower than the first. If I was going to get a medal I would need to pick it up, but I told myself again that the medal did not matter. My only goal was to finish.

Just cross that line. Finish. 26.2 miles. Do not stop.

As I approached mile fourteen my family spotted me from a long way off and I heard their cheers erupt. It was not the first time, or the last, I would fight back tears that day. My sister Emily's voice was crisp and clear. My kids Tanner and Andi ran towards me, all smiles. I reached out and ran my hands over their heads, ruffling their hair but I did not dare stop. My mom and dad looked worried.

"Are you okay?" my dad asked with concern and love in his eyes.

I knew why he was asking. Ninety-five percent of the runners had already passed and they knew my time was slow.

"I'm fine!" I lied, forcing a smile.

I was not fine. I hurt. I was tired. My legs were on fire. My lungs were burning. My chest heaved. Doubt was sapping my strength. I wasn't so concerned anymore about getting a medal. I was concerned about finishing at all. I tried to not let any of this show, but I wasn't sure they bought it. My wife Carina jogged along beside me for a few yards and we spoke. I have no memory of what we said. I know her well enough to spot when she is masking worry and concern. She has never been good at hiding it. I left them behind and they called out words of love and encouragement.

Fifteen. The small pack of runners around me was now very thin. I knew there were still people behind me but I had no idea how many. I didn't look. All around us spectators were packing up and leaving, water tables were being broken down and put away. Entertainment booths were closing up. Musical bands were packing instruments and coiling electrical cords. I couldn't decide if all of this was demoralizing or if it encouraged me to try harder. The old man with the gray beard and crooked back had passed me long ago and was so far ahead of me I could not see him. I was being left in the dust by an eighty-year-old man who couldn't even stand up straight.

Sixteen. Two race officials on bikes rode up next to me. "How's it going?" one asked. He looked at me intently and I knew he was charged with monitoring the slowest runners.

"I'm still going!" I replied, and I showed him a smile. Then I added, "Where's the bus?"

The bus.

It comes along at the very back of the marathon and picks up runners who can't finish. You don't have to get on it, but if it reaches the finish line before you then you don't get an official time or a medal. I wanted his answer to be, "It's WAY back there, don't even worry about it." But that was not his answer.

"It's about a mile back," he said, and then rode away.

My heart plunged. I had no hope. If the bus was that close at sixteen miles I knew I would never finish. I had been right that morning when I felt like an impostor. What was I thinking? What on earth had given me the insane idea that I could do a marathon?

Although I kept moving, a sense of pointless certainty had overcome me. Why keep going? The bus would soon pass me and my day would be over before I even reached mile twenty. I felt ashamed. My mom, my dad, my sisters, and her kids had all flown into town to support me. My wife and kids were here, and I was going to fail.

Seventeen. My family was again waiting and when they spotted me they cheered just as loudly as last time. Andi and Tanner again ran forward to greet me and I forced a thin smile for them, but for the rest of my family, I didn't even try.

"I don't think I'm going to make it," I said honestly to Carina. The fact that I was still moving forward at all was only for show. In a few blocks the bus would pass me up, and this early in the race it would be embarrassing to keep going.

Instead of being worried or sad, to my surprise, my pregnant angel of a wife declared with an enthusiastic smile, "I'm coming with you!" She tossed her coat aside and picked up a stride beside me. This was unexpected, but was also exactly what I needed. Having her jog along beside me lifted my spirits and gave me a bounce to my step. She was happy, encouraging, and kept telling me what a great job I was doing. At least, I thought, I won't be alone when the bus passes me.

Eighteen. I asked her to look back and see if she could spot the bus. It was about two blocks behind us. A mixture of relief and discouragement washed over me. I was relieved that I had managed to stay ahead of it for two miles, but discouraged that it was so close. It had gone from a mile back to two blocks back. And I still had 7.2 miles to go. At least, I told myself, I can stay ahead of it for a little longer. If I could make it to mile twenty that would at least be a respectable showing.

Nineteen. I had to ask my wife to please stop talking. I loved her, but listening to her required energy and concentration that was needed in my legs. The bus was so close I could smell the exhaust, and looking around me, I was now the only marathoner I could see.

Twenty. My pregnant, heroic and now very tired wife was replaced by my dad. Despite his attire of dress pants and loafers his expression told me he was looking forward to helping his boy. As he fell in beside me and took up a pace to match mine, he began offering gentle but experienced runner's advice. He gave me updates every few minutes on the bus. At times I could hear its gears grinding behind me, but the mere fact that it was still *behind* me was at least somewhat promising. Back at mile sixteen, I'd been certain that mile twenty was never going to happen, and I again allowed myself to hope for the finish line. For a while I even outpaced it, putting distance between us.

Twenty-one. Twenty-two. I have no memory of passing these mile markers, but I must have. I do recall reaching the start of The Big Hill. It's a cruel thing, planning a marathon with a giant, three-mile-long incline starting at mile twenty-two. I huffed it the best I could but the bus was making up ground. I passed the remains of a water station where a woman yelled with a smile "YOU STAY AHEAD OF THAT BUS!" Her enthusiasm was contagious and appreciated. A few other joggers also being pushed by the bus caught up with me, and I was surprised at how many had still been behind me.

Twenty-three. My family was again waiting. I was too tired and too dazed to chat, but I think I managed a smile. Against all odds and to my own amazement I'd managed to stay just ahead of the bus for the past eight miles. *Eight Miles!* I knew now that I WAS going to cross the finish line, but the bus was at my heels, literally, and I was certain in the next 3.2 miles it was going to pass me. I was beyond spent and I knew my pace was slowing.

All around me now were other joggers, the last stragglers. I could not imagine where they had come from! I'd been so alone for so long, I thought I was the very last jogger. Their company was a huge morale boost. We were all fighting for the same thing. You could almost tell by the looks on their faces who would make it and who would fail. The young, fit Team Mayo Clinic runner I'd first seen struggling back around mile eight was still here, but there was defeat in his eyes. I was not surprised when he waved at the bus driver who stopped and let him on. He was out.

I passed my friend, the old man with the crooked back and thick gray beard. He was going too slow and wasn't going to keep up, but he recognized me and said in his old voice, "I'm NOT getting on that bus!" I gave him a smile, which was all I had left to offer. A few others gave up the fight and flagged down the driver, while others who were not going to quit but were too spent to keep ahead of it dropped back and out of sight. A rare few still had the energy to spare and surged ahead, leaving us and the bus far behind. I envied them, but if I tried to keep up my body flatly rebelled. I was going at maximum speed.

Part of me wanted to let the bus pass so I could stop working so hard to keep ahead of it. I said to my dad between gasps, "Maybe I'll... be glad when... it's past... so I... can... SLOW DOWN!" My legs were like rubber. About every fifth step I had to catch myself from wobbling and falling down. I felt woozy, nauseous and lightheaded. My vision was slushy. Jogging had long ago stopped being automatic, and it took actual, painful concentration to lift a foot, move it forward, set it down, and repeat with the other foot. I ached deeply to rest, to stop, to be done. I wanted to cry but that would have required energy. It was fatigue and pain like nothing I'd ever experienced. Voices were telling me, "It can all be over, right now. All you have to do is wave at that bus driver and he'll let you rest. You can collapse in a seat and be done. You can stop. This pain and misery can end. Right now."

I was seriously considering listening to these voices and the only thing that kept me going, the *only* thing, was the knowledge that my family was waiting for me at the finish line. Although I might be willing to disappoint myself, I was not willing to disappoint them.

Twenty-four. It was at some point around here that I recall a few final lingering spectators looking at me with pity in their eyes but still trying to encourage me. "You're looking good!" one of them said, and if I'd had the energy I would have retorted, "You suck at lying." But I didn't have the strength, so I ignored them.

At long last, after nine miles of fighting it, the bus pulled even with me. At mile sixteen I would have been horrified, but at mile twenty-four I no longer cared. I had put up a noble fight. The driver poked his head out and said, "Just because I'm passing you doesn't mean you have to stop, and you can still get an official time, but you'll need to catch up with me. Keep going. You might get your second wind."

I smiled, but only to myself. My second wind? Dude! My third and fourth winds were already long ago cashed out. As the bus eked past me I tried a few times to pour on the speed and keep up with it, but I finally gasped to my dad, "I'm done... racing it... I just wanna... finish." If I kept chasing the bus I knew I might not finish at all. It moved further away from me and I had to let go of the disappointment of knowing I was not going to get my medal.

Just cross that line. Finish. 26.2 miles. Do not stop.

Twenty-five. My dad was faithfully trotting along beside me. Water stations were closed now, but he kept running ahead of me to find water and keep a bottle full. Next to me now were giant garbage trucks with volunteers tossing bags of used cups into them, moving trucks with people stacking up water tables, and golf carts scurrying around with people tossing "no parking" signs into the back of them. Two or three of us still plotted along, knowing we would not get a medal, but determined to cross that line.

Twenty-six. The end was in sight as I came to the top of Cathedral Hill in St. Paul. Looking down I could see the bus at the finish line, along with my family. They were the only people at the otherwise empty finish line. I was determined to finish strong. Ignoring all pain and discomfort, I turned up the speed the best I could and actually ran down the hill and across the finish line. I literally collapsed, and in an instant, I was surrounded by loving family members. They congratulated me, cheered me, asked me what I needed, offered water, fruit, and pop. I took it all.

I'm not sure how long I sat there, but I didn't move until the pain in my chest was mostly gone. With help, I stood up and wobbled towards a lady who was giving out foil blankets to the last few of us who had crossed the finish line late. I recognized all of them, and we smiled the best we could at each other. I never got an "official" time, so I don't know exactly how long it took me to jog 26.2 miles, but our best guesstimate is about 6:19:00.

My wife, perhaps sensing my sadness at not getting a medal, gave me a giant hug and a kiss, held my cheeks in her hands, looked into my eyes and said, "You did it, Casey. You RAN A MARATHON!"

And then it hit me. She was right. I had done it.

I had run a marathon.

For the last of many times that day I fought back tears. It had been six months of training. Long, hard, inconvenient, painful training. My family had all sacrificed and arranged their life around my runs, especially for the last twenty-four Saturdays. On countless weekday nights it would have been so much easier to stay home, watch a little TV, read a good book, or go to bed early. On these nights I had to ask myself, "What do I want more? Do I want to stay at home and watch a little TV? Or do I want to finish a marathon?" It had been very much a team effort, and it had paid off. I had just jogged 26.2 miles and I had not stopped once along the way. Twenty-six point two miles. I had crossed the finish line. I finished.

Lots of people have asked me, "How was the marathon?" Some were just being polite. Others I could tell honestly wanted an answer, but I didn't know what to say. How do you wrap up everything I've just said here, plus six months of training, and put it all into a one sentence answer? The best answer I could come up with was this:

It was thrilling. It was terrible. It was spiritual. It was brutal.

And I am going to do it again.

This page titled [9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?](#) is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Casey Crookston](#).

9.4: In Sight of Myself

This narrative essay, developed from a journal prompt in class, shows the beauty of Natalie Goldberg's advice to "give things the dignity of names" in her advice essay entitled, "Be Specific." Valentine takes the reader through the settings of a mid-sized midwestern town, naming everything so the reader can be right there in the scene. Sometimes in nonfiction writing, the author must take liberties with names to protect identities, but Valentine captures the essence of identities of places and people in this piece. Again in this piece, exposition is peppered throughout as the author frames a journey of identities in a simple trip to the hair salon.

"So, what now?" I asked.

My boyfriend, Ben, slipped into the seat beside me. We were sitting in his car with two chairs stuffed into the backseat. The nerdy little bar we used to have our D&D sessions at, The Bronze Dragon, had recently closed down, and the owner made us the first to know when everything would be half price at their garage sale. After two and a half years, Ben and I would be living together in a month, and two chairs for \$12 felt like a steal. A small, rotund plush of a black cat in a pumpkin suit smiled at me from the dash. I had always found it strikingly adorable. The perfect impulse purchase, if you asked me.

"I don't know! We could get lunch, go home and watch a show, or go somewhere else?"

His hair had fallen in front of his face when he got in. He pushed it back behind his ear. An idea clicked in my mind.

"We could go get our hair cut together? We've both been needing to do that."

He looked over to me, grinning and giddy at the prospect. "That would be cuuute!"

I rolled my eyes fondly. I preferred keeping mine short. It only needed a few inches trimmed to escape the awkward length it had grown into. Ben, on the other hand, had grown his hair out just past his shoulders. Chopping it off was like a sign the sweltering summer heat was really here, and he'd been complaining for weeks about needing to get it done.

I looked through salons on my phone, checking for what was closest and their wait times while he queued music for our ride.

"I usually go to Cost Cutters," he offered.

"I've never been there. I've always gone to Great Clips, the one down near Central."

"Would you prefer to go there?"

"I don't know. It's whatever you prefer." I spoke in that rushed '*don't ask me to make a decision*' voice I've always had when unsure of something. I really didn't care much, so long as they could cut hair straight and give me what I asked for.

Ben went silent in thought as he weighed the options. His lips pursed in thought as he finished curating the perfect playlist for the drive. He pressed play before casting it to the side. As the music began, he placed his hands on the wheel and smiled.

"Let's go there."

We stopped back at his dad's house to drop off our chairs and sat on the couch scrolling through our phones for reference photos of the last time we each cut our hair. With the time spent giggling and pausing to show unrelated, goofy pictures we had of each other in our camera rolls, it took longer than it should have. By the time our favorite photos were all sorted out, the salon's wait times were all about the same. I placed our names on the online check in for the nearest one out in Onalaska.

When we arrived, two empty seats greeted us at the front of the salon just behind the counter. I showed the stylist my pictures as I relayed our day. I could hear Ben doing the same.

It always felt exciting, sitting in one of those seats, with my face staring back at me in the mirror and not knowing what it would look like once it was done.

I'd never done anything special with my hair as a child. I'd get it trimmed when I was small, back when my grandma would take me to the mall to cut off any split ends in exchange for lollipops and temporary tattoos. It was for maintenance rather than anything of self-expression. The thought never occurred to me to cut it any other way.

The more I grew, so too did the itch sitting under my skin. It was like something existed between my ribs and my heart, waiting to either implode or crawl its way out. I noticed it in fourth grade, when puberty began and I started to learn more about human

anatomy. It spread through my veins like a fungus, eating at my bones and consuming my body.

I told myself every girl felt that way. Everyone dreaded the thought of what it meant to be a woman, and how their body had begun to change. Everyone wanted to be something other than they were. Everyone hated the feeling of leaving the locker room and entering the gym, standing silently in the center as teams were divided into boys versus girls. Everyone hated walking to their designated side.

Once I got to middle school, I was begging to do something with my hair. To dye it, cut it, or do anything else that would make it feel more like mine. By the time I was in high school it had grown past my hips. I felt like a dark-haired version of Rapunzel. It was a chore to maintain, but more than anything it just wasn't me. I hated seeing myself in mirrors, and I hardly ever wanted to be in photos.

Every time I brought up the desire to cut my hair, I was bombarded with the idea that I was going to regret it. It took people years to get the length I had, what if I hated having it short? It's not like I could get it back once the job was done. And what would guys think? They might not want a girl with short hair. Even my brother tried to discourage me, saying I'd be less likely to get a job because employers wouldn't want me.

It all sounded absurd. My mom kept her hair around shoulder length at most, and my brother hadn't cut his hair in years. I knew girls with pixie cuts who had boys chasing at their feet, and short hair had always seemed to be the more professional or mature choice both on TV and in my own community. I didn't care about any of those things, though. If anything, less harassment from boys sounded like an incredible win. I wasn't trying to be a pretty girl or an attractive career woman. I was trying to be me.

By sophomore year, I finally broke. I had asked again, and again, and again. The empty promises of doing it 'someday' had been built like a sandcastle waiting to be washed away by the shore, and my tide was coming in. If my mom wouldn't take me to get it done professionally, I would take a pair of scissors and do it myself, and we both knew how lovely that would turn out.

My mom relented and agreed to take me to a salon the next day. She wasn't happy when I held her to it, waking her up and reminding her every few minutes of what was going to happen. Still, she traded her nerves for optimism for my sake. I showed her photos of styles I liked, and asked what she thought would look good on me. When we arrived, I listened to her anxious chatter with the stylist about never having done this before. All the while, I was bursting with excitement for the person I would become.

A collection of thin black ponytails were gathered in a plastic bag. I hoped they could be donated to someone who would love them more than I ever could. The rest had carpeted the floor around me, like someone had dragged in the hide of a dead bear and laid it out at my feet.

When the stylist spun me around, I stared in the mirror. It wasn't exactly what I asked for. The stylist had her own opinion on what would suit me. She had given me a short bob, one that just reached my chin. It looked more like something she'd give to a woman in her 30s or 40s than a teen, but it was nothing a little extra styling couldn't fix. I had already started considering where I left my bobby pins for when I got home.

Still, it was a step in the right direction. My head felt lighter than ever. I shook my head around and ran my fingers through it with astonishment every time. The weight on my scalp and the dysphoria it gave me had been cut off within an hour, as if it was never there to begin with. I still looked like a girl, but this, at least, was something I could make work.

In the days after, I'd catch my reflection in the mirror, and more often, I found myself smiling back. My camera roll began to fill with pictures of me, selfies sent to friends of the things I was up to, or just because I liked the way I looked. I had never cared to do that before.

The stylist's scissors snipped at my hair as she combed through it to make sure each layer looked nice. Each little *shik* sound of the blades coming together and another clump of hair falling onto my shoulders sent a jolt of excitement up my spine. She'd ask now and then how I felt about things, like if she had parted it right, or if I wanted to go shorter or keep the length as it was. She listened to my thoughts and trusted my judgment. This was her job, she told me, and this was for me. It seems every time I go, every time near the end where I'm asked if I like it as it is, I find myself asking:

"Can we go a little shorter?"

She took out the clippers and carefully started to trim the hair at the base of my neck. The loud buzz rang in my ears like a massive mosquito flying around me. I've never gotten used to it being so close, but I resist the urge to shoo it away nonetheless. Once

finished, I felt the tiny hairs poking at my neck. I'd probably leave traces of them everywhere I went until I got in the shower.

When the stylist asked again how I felt about things, I told her it looked good. Hell, I loved it. She pulled the cape off my shoulders, letting more stray hairs fall to the floor. They stared at me, waiting to be swept up as I stepped away. I glanced over to my partner. His golden-brown locks had joined mine on the graveyard of the floor, and his stylist was just finishing neatening the edges. I couldn't help but laugh as I told the others there how they had sheared him like a sheep.

The moment we were out the door, he grabbed my shoulders and began shaking me around with excitement.

"You look so good! You're so handsome!"

He rambled on more compliments. If a positive word for appearance existed, it was only a matter of seconds before it came out of his mouth. I laughed and told him the same. He'd done this every time I chopped my hair, got new clothes, or simply tried something new with my makeup.

It had been just under two years since my first haircut when we met. Despite the confident personality I presented with, I still felt entirely other. It had seemed the world would never love me for who I was, and I had made peace with that fact. Walking through the halls on the first day of my senior year, I didn't know what name I'd go by. When I reached my class, my favorite teacher asked, and I threw caution to the wind. Soon after, Ben followed me in and took a seat across the room. Soon after, he gained a new crush.

Ben drove me back to my house. Songs I introduced him to took over his taste in music, and they played through the speakers as we both sang along. At every spotlight, he'd look over to me, and that wide, shining grin would consume him again.

His unrelenting positivity absorbed my insecurities like a sponge and squeezed them out into something new. I still get that itch, the one that says I'll only ever be seen as some frail young girl, and not whatever gender-messed version of me I'd rather people see, but it's calmer now. Less and less do I find myself concerned with anyone else.

I view myself like a butterfly emerged from its chrysalis, or maybe one still climbing its way out. Occasionally, I offer a friend a rare photo from before I cut my hair, something from school or my mom's Facebook since I never kept any myself. Their eyes flash between the photo and me, taking in every similarity and every difference between the two.

"You look like a different person," they tell me. "You look more like yourself."

I'm inclined to agree.

This page titled [9.4: In Sight of Myself](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Virgil Valentine](#).

Works Cited

- “An Interview with Katherine Boo.” BookBrowse. Book Browsers, LLC. 1997-2025. https://www.bookbrowse.com/author_interviews/full/index.cfm/author_number/2129/katherine-boo
- Ballenger, Bruce. *Crafting Truth: Short Studies in Creative Nonfiction*. Longman (Pearson), 2011.
- Bestsellers—Paperback Nonfiction. *The New York Times*. 11 May 2025. <https://www.nytimes.com/books/best-s...ck-nonfiction/>
- Boo, Katherine. *Behind the Beautiful Forevers*. Random House, 2012.
- Dreyer, Benjamin. “Writers, Be Wary of Throat Clearers and Wan Intensifiers. Very, very Wary.” *The Washington Post*. 12 Oct. 2022. <https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/2022/10/12/editing-writing-word-choice-avoid-very/>. Accessed 5 July 2024.
- Ellis, Sherry, ed. *Now Write! Nonfiction: Memoir, Journalism, and Creative Nonfiction Exercises from Today’s Best Writers and Teachers*. Jeremy P. Tarcher/Penguin, New York, 2009.
- Go, Kenji. “Montaigne’s ‘Cannibals’ and ‘The Tempest’ Revisited.” *Studies in Philology*, vol. 109, no. 4, 2012, pp. 455–73. JSTOR, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/24392013>. Accessed 6 July 2024.
- Goldberg, Natalie. *Writing Down the Bones*. Shambala, Boston & London, 1986.
- Gutkind, Lee. “What is Creative Nonfiction?” *Creative Nonfiction Magazine*. <https://creativenonfiction.org/what-is-cnf/>. Accessed 5 July 2024.
- Hamlin, William. *Montaigne’s English Journey*. Oxford University Press, New York, 2014.
- Hill, Pati. “Truman Capote, The Art of Fiction No. 17”. *The Paris Review*. 16 (Spring–Summer 1957). Archived from the original on October 7, 2010. <https://www.theparisreview.org/interviews/4867/the-art-of-fiction-no-17-truman-capote>. Accessed 3 July 2024.
- Jackson, Lawrence. “The City That Bleeds.” *The Best American Essays: 2017*, edited by Leslie Jamison, Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, Boston, 2017, pp. 45-59.
- Kidd, Sue Monk. “Opening the Hand.” *Why We Write About Ourselves: Twenty Memoirists on Why They Expose Themselves (and Others) in the Name of Literature*, edited by Meredith Maran, Plume, 2016, pp. 121–128.
- King, Stephen. *On Writing: A Memoir of the Craft*. Scribner, New York, 2020.
- MANSON, M., L. “CLIMAX.” *The Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, edited by Roland Green et al., 4th ed., Princeton University Press, 2012. Credo Reference, <https://search.credoreference.com/ar...U6MzA2MDQx?aid=114475>.
- Moore, Dinty. “Why We Call it Creative Nonfiction.” *Creative Nonfiction: True Stories, Well Told*. CNF. Issue 56, Summer 2015. <https://creativenonfiction.org/writi...ve-nonfiction/>. Accessed 8 June 2024
- Moran, Vikki. “Traditional Storytelling: A Voyage for the Soul in Scotland.” *HERLIFE Magazine*, 30 June 2020, www.herlifemagazine.com/blog/travel/traditional-storytelling-a-voyage-for-the-soul-in-scotland/. Accessed 9 June 2024.
- Morris, Wesley. “Last Taboo.” *The Best American Essays: 2017*, edited by Leslie Jamison, Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, Boston, 2017, pp. 156-175.
- Morrison, Toni. “Reading Toni Morrison’s 1973 Summer Essay ‘Cooking Out’.” *The New York Times Book Review*, 2 June 2019, p. 6(L). Gale General OneFile, link.gale.com/apps/doc/A587414163/GPS?u=la74598&sid=bookmark-GPS&xid=0454cff8. Accessed 3 May 2024.
- Notarnicola, Christopher. “Indigent Disposition.” *The Best American Essays: 2017*, edited by Leslie Jamison, Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, Boston, 2017, pp. 176-179.
- O’grady, Megan. “These Literary Memoirs Take a Different Tack.” *The New York Times*, The New York Times, 29 Sept. 2021, www.nytimes.com/2021/09/29/t-magazine/memoirs-books-nonfiction-identity.html. Accessed 28 May 2024.

- Porterfield, Carlie. "Here's What We Know About Prince Harry And Meghan Markle's \$135 Million Deals." *Forbes Magazine*. Forbes, 19 Jan. 2023, <https://www.forbes.com/sites/carlieporterfield/2023/01/19/how-rich-are-prince-harry-and-meghan-markle-heres-what-we-know-about-the-power-couples-135-million-deals/>. Accessed 30 June 2024.
- Resnick, Sarah. "H." *The Best American Essays: 2017*, edited by Leslie Jamison, Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, Boston, 2017, pp. 203-231.
- Sedaris, David. "Dentists Without Borders." *The New Yorker*. 26 March 2012, <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2012/04/02/dentists-without-borders>. Accessed 27 Jul. 2024.
- Shapiro, Dani. "Why I Write About Myself." *Why We Write About Ourselves: Twenty Memoirists on Why They Expose Themselves (and Others) in the Name of Literature*, edited by Meredith Maran, Plume, 2016, pp. 170-177.
- Shakespeare, William. *Hamlet*. Edited by Barbara A. Mowat and Paul Werstine, Folger Shakespeare Library, Simon & Schuster, 2012, Act 3, Scene 2, lines 20–22.
- Smith, Dinitia. "A Career In Letters, 50 Years and Counting." *The New York Times*. The New York Times Company, 23 Jan. 2007. <https://www.nytimes.com/2007/01/23/books/23loom.html>. Accessed 1 July 2024.
- Spivack, Kathleen. "Words as Inspiration." *Now, Write! Nonfiction: Memoir, Journalism, and Creative Nonfiction Exercises from Today's Best Writers and Teachers*, edited by Sherry Ellis, Penguin, New York, 2009, pp. 19-22.
- Stegner, Wallace. *Where the Bluebird Sings to the Lemonade Springs*. Random House, 2002.
- Topol, Sarah. "Tea and Kidnapping: In the Desert with the World's Friendliest Hostage-Takers." *The Atlantic*, Oct. 2012. <https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2012/10/tea-and-kidnapping/309078/>. Accessed 27 Jul. 2024.
- University of Zurich. "Every person has a unique brain anatomy." *ScienceDaily*. ScienceDaily, 10 July 2018. www.sciencedaily.com/releases/2018/07/180710104631.htm. Accessed 23 July 2024.

Index

A

audience

[4: Content](#)

B

biography

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

braided essay

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

Braiding Sweetgrass

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

brain dump

[2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#)

brainstorming

[2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#)

C

celebrity memoirs

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

character

[4: Content](#)

character development

[4: Content](#)

community

[1: Introduction](#)

concise wording

[5: Writing Standards](#)

conclusions

[7: Openings and Closings](#)

content

[4: Content](#)

creative nonfiction

[6: Artistry](#)

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

creativity

[6: Artistry](#)

D

dialogue

[5: Writing Standards](#)

E

empathy

[1: Introduction](#)

essay

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

F

figurative language

[6: Artistry](#)

first lines

[7: Openings and Closings](#)

food narrative

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

Frank McCourt

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

Freytag's pyramid

[5: Writing Standards](#)

H

hermit crab essay

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

I

identity

[4: Content](#)

interview

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

L

literary elements

[5: Writing Standards](#)

M

memory

[4: Content](#)

metaphor

[6: Artistry](#)

N

narrative forms

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

narrative structure

[5: Writing Standards](#)

nonfiction

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

P

personal narratives

[1: Introduction](#)

prompts

[2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#)

R

revision

[6: Artistry](#)

S

setting

[4: Content](#)

stories

[1: Introduction](#)

T

top ten list

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

travel narrative

[3: Bring Form to the Storm](#)

V

veracity

[8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#)

Glossary

Sample Word 1 | Sample Definition 1

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [Nurturing Truth \(Heise\)](#)

Webpages: 26

Applicable Restrictions: Noncommercial

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#): 50% (13 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 46.2% (12 pages)
- [CC BY-NC 4.0](#): 3.8% (1 page)

By Page

- [Nurturing Truth \(Heise\)](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [1: Introduction](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [3: Bring Form to the Storm](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [4: Content](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [5: Writing Standards](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [6: Artistry](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [7: Openings and Closings](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9: Voices and Truths](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9.1: Bad Ass](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.2: The Crabby Contractor](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.4: In Sight of Myself](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Works Cited](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Image Attributions](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)

Image Attributions

Chapter Tile Images

0: Front Matter

Ralf Roletschek, CC BY 3.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/3.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:13-11-02-olb-by-RalfR-03.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

1: Introduction

W.carter, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Tree with red apples in Barkedal 4.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

2: Getting Started

Guywitney, CC BY-SA 4.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Storm_season,_Kawambwa,_Zambia.jpg

3: Bring Form

gnuckx, CC BY 2.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Writing on the Sunset Italy Rome - Creative Commons by gnuckx \(3491709853\).jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

4: Content

LaurelG, CC BY-SA 4.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Smarties Candy Tablets in Jars.JPG - Wikimedia Commons](#)

5: Writing Standards

florianric from Deutschland, CC BY 2.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Toolbox \(7263382550\).jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

6: Artistry

Hendrik Kueck from Vancouver, Canada, CC BY 2.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Poi circles.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

7: Openings and Closings

John Samuel, CC BY-SA 4.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:Green door, Bruges.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene

Harald Krichel, CC BY-SA 4.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0>>, via Wikimedia Commons [File:David Sedaris-4724.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

9: Voices and Truths: Readings

Johan Fredriksson, CC BY-SA 3.0 <<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0>>, via Wikimedia [File:Royal Typewriter, Söderlångvik museum.jpg - Wikimedia Commons](#)

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [Nurturing Truth \(Heise\)](#)

Webpages: 26

Applicable Restrictions: Noncommercial

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#): 50% (13 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 46.2% (12 pages)
- [CC BY-NC 4.0](#): 3.8% (1 page)

By Page

- [Nurturing Truth \(Heise\)](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [1: Introduction](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2: Getting Started with The Storm in Your Brain](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [3: Bring Form to the Storm](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [4: Content](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [5: Writing Standards](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [6: Artistry](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [7: Openings and Closings](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [8: The Creative Nonfiction Scene from Page to Stage](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9: Voices and Truths](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [9.1: Bad Ass](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.2: The Crabby Contractor](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.3: I'm Not an Impostor—Am I?](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [9.4: In Sight of Myself](#) - [CC BY-NC 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Works Cited](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Image Attributions](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)